Highlights

Eclipse-Modulated Transient Energy Pumping in Near-Polar Low Earth Orbit for Spin-Stabilised Solar Sails

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- Passive solar sails can gain semi-major axis transiently in near-polar LEO.
- Gain exists only in a narrow LTDN–pitch band; eclipse timing enables it.
- Apogee pumping, eccentricity growth and perigee erosion make it self-limiting.
- Open-source propagator reproduces the gain lobe and eclipse causality.
- STK cross-check validates J_2 below 0.05 km over 14 d; drag dominates error.

Eclipse-Modulated Transient Energy Pumping in Near-Polar Low Earth Orbit for Spin-Stabilised Solar Sails*

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ABSTRACT

This paper pursues two goals: to verify the existence of a passive orbital-energy-gain region for spin-stabilised solar sails in near-polar low Earth orbit (LEO), and to validate the open-source propagator used to map it against two independent flight-dynamics references: the industry-standard Ansys STK/Astrogator environment and the open-source Orekit library. Establishing such a regime with an inspectable, verified, and freely available toolchain matters because LEO has become the cost-effective testbed of choice for maturing solar- and drag-sail technology on low-cost CubeSat platforms, where reliable pre-flight prediction of the coupled solar-radiation-pressure (SRP) and drag dynamics is essential. Using a reduced analytical model and three-dimensional numerical propagations, we show that a bounded net-gain regime does exist, but only within a narrow region of LTDN–pitch space. At 700 km, only 89 of 900 sampled cases ($\sim 10\%$) exhibit positive semi-major-axis excursion within the 14-day analysis window, with the strongest case reaching $\Delta a \approx +20.07$ km at LTDN 12.266 h and pitch 24.8°. Eclipse is causally decisive: for the representative gain case the eclipse-on trajectory reaches $\Delta a \approx +10.31$ km by day 14, whereas the eclipse-off counterpart falls to $\Delta a \approx -47.75$ km; orbit-resolved SRP work diagnostics show that gain occurs only when eclipse suppresses predominantly negative-work portions of the SRP cycle. Longer-horizon propagation shows the effect is transient and self-limiting: the representative gain case peaks at 7098.211 km on day 26.50 before declining to 7064.717 km by day 75, below its initial 7078.137 km, as apogee pumping, perigee erosion, and eccentricity growth progressively increase drag exposure and weaken the favourable SRP projection. Independent open-source and Orekit propagators both reproduce the gain lobe, the eclipse-driven sign reversal, and the transient–breakdown signature, confirming that the mechanism is not a numerical artefact. Cross-validation against STK shows that two-body and J_2 dynamics agree to better than 0.05 km over 14 days, while the drag-induced decay differs by close to an order of magnitude despite matching instantaneous force; the second reference resolves that ambiguity, since Orekit reproduces the open-source 14-day decay to 4×10^{-10} km, localising the discrepancy to STK's drag application rather than to the open-source implementation. Orekit also passes the test STK could not: its N-plate SRP model does couple to an inertially-fixed sail attitude, so the passive-sail SRP dynamics are confirmed against a second tool rather than only analytically. Isolating each modelling choice in turn shows that atmosphere co-rotation and the geodetic-versus-geocentric altitude convention shift the 14-day decay by at most 19%, whereas substituting a different atmosphere model changes it by factors up to 5.9 — identifying the choice of atmospheric density model, rather than the SRP mechanism or the drag conventions, as the dominant uncertainty governing where the regime is realisable. A further numerical caveat emerges: because a binary umbra makes the SRP force discontinuous, fixed-step integration converges at first rather than fourth order and overstates the gain, appreciably so at the step sizes large sweeps encourage. The paper therefore establishes a validated but narrow result: eclipse timing can enable a real, bounded, transient energy-pumping regime in near-polar LEO, its existence is robust across independent propagators, and its quantitative threshold is drag-model dependent. The full toolchain and data are released openly.

1. Introduction

Solar radiation pressure (SRP) provides a continuous, propellant-free means of modifying spacecraft orbits, and has been demonstrated in missions including IKAROS [1, 2], LightSail 2 [3], and the Advanced Composite Solar Sail System [4]. Recent reviews summarise the current state of solar sailing technology and mission heritage [5, 6]. While active solar sailing enables controlled trajectory shaping, the possibility of achieving meaningful orbital energy change under purely passive configurations remains less well understood, particularly in low Earth orbit (LEO) where atmospheric drag and gravitational perturbations are significant. The use of solar sails in LEO has been explored for deorbiting [7, 8] and for altitude maintenance [9], but the short-horizon interaction between eclipse timing and SRP work balance has received limited attention.

Prior work has examined the coupled effects of solar radiation pressure and atmospheric drag on high area-to-mass spacecraft. In particular, Colombo and McInnes [10] demonstrated that asymmetric SRP, including the influence of Earth eclipse, can be exploited to balance drag losses and produce long-lived Earth-centred orbits without active control. The influence of SRP on high area-to-mass ratio objects has also been studied in the context of long-term orbit evolution and resonance structures [11]. These analyses highlight the importance of SRP–drag interaction and shadow-induced asymmetries in shaping orbital evolution.

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However, much of the existing SRP–drag literature emphasizes long-term or averaged behaviour and equilibrium-like manifolds or "balance" conditions, rather than isolating short-horizon regimes in which the timing of eclipse arcs alters the sign and magnitude of orbit-averaged SRP work.

In near-polar LEO, the interaction between SRP, atmospheric drag, Earth's oblateness (J_2), and eclipse timing produces a dynamically coupled environment in which small perturbations can lead to non-intuitive orbital behaviour over short timescales [12]. In particular, a passively oriented, spin-stabilised sail experiences alternating phases of positive and negative SRP work over each orbit, which would be expected to largely cancel in the absence of asymmetries [13].

However, eclipse introduces a temporal modulation of SRP by removing solar forcing over specific orbital arcs [14]. Depending on the orbital geometry, this can selectively suppress phases in which SRP performs negative work, altering the orbit-averaged energy balance. This raises the question of whether a net increase in semi-major axis can arise over a bounded time horizon under restricted conditions, without active attitude control.

This work investigates that question by isolating and characterising a transient, geometry-dependent energy-pumping regime in near-polar LEO for spin-stabilised solar sails. The aim is not to propose a mission architecture or demonstrate sustained orbit raising, but to identify where the regime exists, explain the eclipse-modulated SRP work-imbalance mechanism, and quantify the conditions under which it appears and breaks down. Using a reduced-order dynamical model and parameter-space sweeps over local time of descending node (LTDN) and sail orientation, we show that short-horizon semi-major-axis growth can occur within a narrow alignment envelope, but that the effect is inherently self-limiting through coupled eccentricity growth, increased drag exposure near perigee, and gradual drift in Sun-relative geometry.

Because the regime is narrow and rests on a fine balance between eclipse-gated SRP work and atmospheric drag, its credibility depends on being reproducible in more than one propagator and on the propagator itself being verified against trusted references. This is not merely a matter of numerical hygiene. LEO has become the pre-eminent low-cost testbed for maturing solar- and drag-sail technology: demonstrators such as NanoSail-D [15], CubeSail [16], InflateSail [17], and CanX-7 [18] have all flown on CubeSat-class platforms precisely because they provide rapid, inexpensive access to space for technology maturation [19, 20], and dedicated studies of sail dynamics in LEO have highlighted the strong and competing roles of drag and SRP in this environment [21, 22]. Predicting whether and where a passive sail can gain energy in this environment therefore requires force-model fidelity in exactly the two effects that this regime hinges on, and tools whose behaviour can be inspected and reproduced by other groups.

Accordingly, this paper has two coupled objectives. The first is scientific: to *verify the existence* of the passive-gain region and characterise its mechanism and limits. The second is methodological: to *validate an open-source propagator* — built specifically for this class of passive-sail SRP–drag problem — against two independent references. The first is Ansys Systems Tool Kit (STK) with the Astrogator module [23, 24], an industry-standard, high-fidelity flight-dynamics environment routinely used as a verification reference for orbit-propagation software [25, 26]. The second is Orekit [27], a mature open-source flight-dynamics library used operationally in European mission analysis, whose source can be inspected by any reader. Other open-source propagators — GMAT [26], poliastro [28], Basilisk [29] and Tudat [30] — make such analyses transparent and repeatable, but only once their force models are shown to agree with a recognised benchmark.

Using two references rather than one proves necessary rather than merely thorough. A single reference can reveal that two tools disagree, but not which of them to believe, and it cannot help at all when the reference tool turns out to be unable to represent the configuration under study — both of which occur here. We therefore present the reduced-order analysis of the gain regime (Sections 3–8) together with an independent open-source re-implementation and a component-by-component cross-validation against both references (Section 9). The validation confirms that the gain regime is not an artefact of a single implementation; it attributes the one substantial inter-tool disagreement; and, by isolating each modelling choice in turn, it sharpens the physical interpretation, identifying the choice of atmospheric density model as the dominant uncertainty for realising the effect and exposing a numerical sensitivity intrinsic to eclipse-gated forcing.

2. Scope and Problem Definition

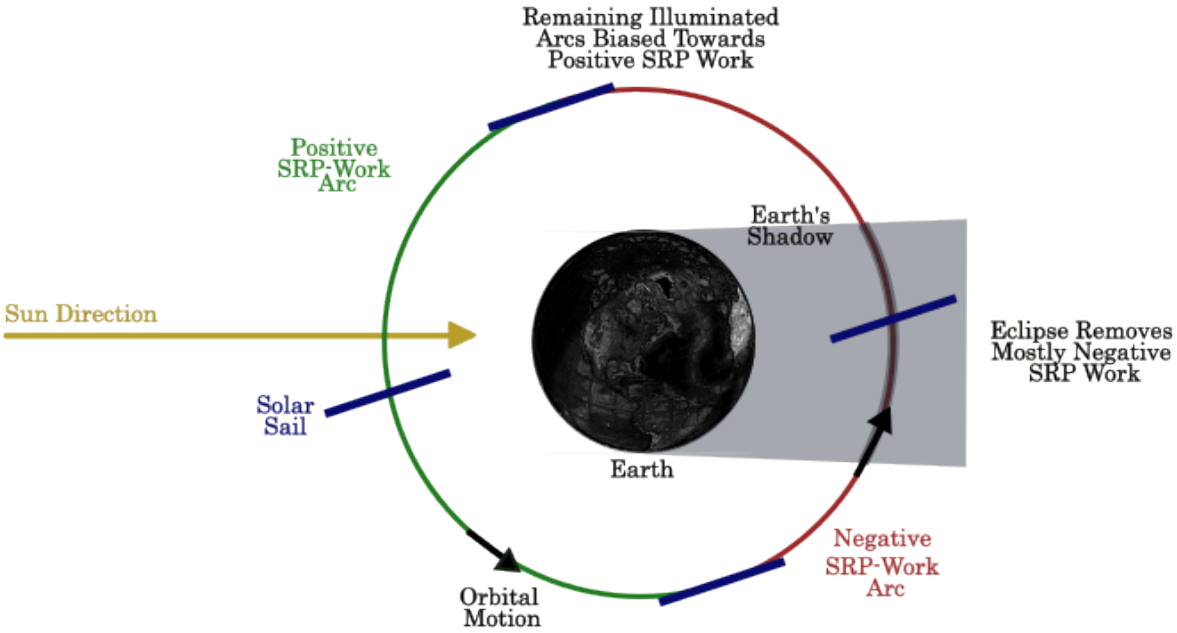


Figure 1: Conceptual schematic of the eclipse-modulated SRP work asymmetry in the reduced mechanism picture. For an inertially fixed sail, solar radiation pressure contributes positive work over part of the illuminated orbit and negative work over another part. If eclipse removes a larger fraction of the unfavourable arc than of the favourable arc, the one-orbit SRP work integral becomes positive. The figure is intended to illustrate the phase-selective gating mechanism, not to represent the full propagated 3D geometry directly.

This work is framed as a bounded orbital-dynamics study of a specific short-horizon regime in near-polar LEO in which solar radiation pressure (SRP) can, under restricted passive conditions, produce a net orbit-averaged energy gain. The system considered is intentionally limited to the coupled effects of central gravity, Earth's oblateness (J_2), atmospheric drag, solar radiation pressure, and eclipse-modulated shadowing, for a spin-stabilised sail whose orientation is fixed in inertial space and not actively controlled.

The primary question is whether eclipse timing can, over a bounded horizon, produce a net positive orbit-averaged energy input by selectively suppressing phases of negative SRP work, and how strongly that effect depends on orbital geometry. The purpose is therefore to isolate and explain a geometric dynamical mechanism, not to demonstrate an operational orbit-raising strategy.

The study is framed around two explicit objectives. The first (scientific) objective is to *verify the existence* of the passive-gain region: to map the constrained dynamical regime, explain its underlying eclipse-modulated SRP work-imbalance mechanism, and determine the conditions under which the observed energy gain emerges and subsequently breaks down. The second (methodological) objective is to *validate the open-source propagator* used for the first: to cross-check its force models, component by component, against the high-fidelity industrial flight-dynamics tool STK Astrogator, and to quantify where the two agree and diverge. The two objectives are complementary — the validation establishes that the gain region is reproducible across independent tools and identifies which force-model choices most strongly govern the result.

Several exclusions are imposed to maintain a controlled scope. This study does not claim disposal-compliant mission design, communications-feasible spacecraft architecture, collision-risk-assessed operations, maintenance of an exact Sun-synchronous orbit, or long-term sustained orbit raising. It does not attempt subsystem-level mission design, active attitude-control implementation, or guidance and feedback control. The external validation performed here is a component-level cross-check of the propagator's force models against STK Astrogator, not a flight-data validation of the mission concept; the results should therefore not be interpreted as a demonstrated mission concept, but as evidence for a bounded dynamical effect within the modelled regime, together with a verified toolchain for studying it. Sun-synchronous-like initial conditions are used only to impose a controlled and interpretable Sun-relative geometry; they are not intended to assert that the vehicle remains on an exactly maintained operational SSO throughout the propagation.

3. Physical Mechanism of Eclipse-Modulated Energy Pumping

This section introduces a reduced analytical picture to isolate the core geometric mechanism by which eclipse timing can bias solar-radiation-pressure (SRP) work over an orbit. Its

purpose is not to derive a design-optimal sail orientation for the full propagated problem, nor to replace the later 3D simulations, but to establish the sign logic of phase-selective forcing in the simplest setting where it can be seen clearly. The full numerical problem considered later includes three-dimensional orbital geometry, J_2-driven nodal precession, drag, eclipse-modulated illumination, and coupled evolution of the orbital elements; the reduced model is therefore used here only as a mechanistic scaffold for interpreting those results.

The reduced argument developed below is used to identify the sign structure of the SRP work integral under eclipse-modulated illumination, and thereby to motivate the later propagated results.

3.1. Orbital energy change and transverse work

The central quantity of interest is the sign of the orbit-averaged transverse SRP work, because the Gauss variational equation for semi-major axis [31, 32] directly links da/dt to the radial and transverse components of the perturbing acceleration. Writing the perturbing acceleration in the local orbital frame as radial (F_R), transverse (F_T), and normal (F_N) components, the semi-major-axis equation is

$$\frac{da}{dt} = \frac{2a^2}{h}\left[e\sin\theta\, F_R + (1 + e\cos\theta)\, F_T\right], \tag{1}$$

where F_R and F_T are the radial and transverse components of the perturbing acceleration, θ is the true anomaly, a is the semi-major axis, and h is the specific angular momentum.

For near-circular low Earth orbits ($e \approx 0$), this reduces to

$$\frac{da}{dt} \approx \frac{2a^2}{h} F_T = \frac{2}{n} F_T, \tag{2}$$

where $n = \sqrt{\mu/a^3}$ is the mean motion. The semi-major axis evolution is therefore governed primarily by the transverse component of the perturbing force. Equivalently, since the specific orbital energy is

$$\varepsilon = -\frac{\mu}{2a}, \tag{3}$$

its rate of change is

$$\dot{\varepsilon} = \mathbf{a}_p \cdot \mathbf{v} = F_T v, \tag{4}$$

for a circular orbit, where $\mathbf{a}_p$ is the perturbing acceleration and $v = \sqrt{\mu/a}$ is the orbital speed. Hence, in the near-circular setting used here, positive transverse work corresponds to increasing orbital energy and increasing semi-major axis, while negative transverse work has the opposite effect.

This makes the sign of the orbit-averaged transverse work the central quantity of interest in the reduced mechanism. In particular, if the SRP contribution satisfies

$$\int_0^T F_T\, dt > 0, \tag{5}$$

over one orbital period T, then the orbit-integrated SRP work is positive and the corresponding one-orbit change in orbital energy, and hence in semi-major axis, is favourable.

3.2. Passive symmetry and cancellation in the fully illuminated case

Consider first an idealised 2D planar circular orbit with the Sun fixed in inertial space. Let the Sun direction define the $+x$ axis, and parameterise the spacecraft position and velocity by

$$\mathbf{r} = r(\cos\theta, \sin\theta), \qquad \mathbf{v} = v(-\sin\theta, \cos\theta), \tag{6}$$

where θ is the orbital phase measured from the sunward direction. For a passively oriented, spin-stabilised sail with fixed inertial attitude, let the sail normal be

$$\mathbf{n} = (\cos\beta, \sin\beta), \tag{7}$$

where β is the constant pitch angle measured from the Sun line.

For an ideal reflecting sail under constant illumination, the SRP acceleration has fixed inertial direction and may be written in the form [13]

$$\mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{SRP}} = a_0 \cos^2\beta\, \mathbf{n}, \tag{8}$$

where a_0 is the characteristic SRP acceleration scale. The instantaneous specific power is then

$$\dot{\varepsilon} = \mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{SRP}} \cdot \mathbf{v} = a_0 \cos^2\beta\, \mathbf{n} \cdot \mathbf{v}. \tag{9}$$

Substituting for $\mathbf{n}$ and $\mathbf{v}$ gives

$$\mathbf{n} \cdot \mathbf{v} = v(-\sin\theta\cos\beta + \cos\theta\sin\beta) = v\sin(\beta - \theta), \tag{10}$$

so that

$$\dot{\varepsilon} = a_0 v \cos^2\beta\, \sin(\beta - \theta). \tag{11}$$

Over a fully illuminated circular orbit, using $dt = (r/v)\, d\theta$, the net specific energy change is

$$\Delta\varepsilon_{\mathrm{full}} = \int_0^{2\pi} \dot{\varepsilon}\, dt = a_0 r \cos^2\beta \int_0^{2\pi} \sin(\beta - \theta)\, d\theta. \tag{12}$$

Since

$$\int_0^{2\pi} \sin(\beta - \theta)\, d\theta = 0, \tag{13}$$

it follows that

$$\Delta\varepsilon_{\mathrm{full}} = 0. \tag{14}$$

Equation (14) formalises the passive symmetry argument: under continuous illumination, a fixed-attitude sail experiences alternating orbital phases of positive and negative transverse work that cancel exactly over one revolution. In this idealised baseline case, the one-orbit net change in orbital energy vanishes despite non-zero instantaneous SRP forcing.

3.3. Eclipse as a selective gating mechanism

The previous cancellation result changes fundamentally once eclipse is introduced. In a midnight orbit under a cylindrical shadow model, the eclipse is centred on the anti-solar direction $\theta = \pi$ and spans the interval

$$\theta \in [\pi - \delta, \pi + \delta], \qquad \delta = \arcsin\left(\frac{R_E}{r}\right), \tag{15}$$

where R_E is the Earth radius and r is the orbital radius. The illuminated arcs are therefore

$$[0, \pi - \delta] \cup [\pi + \delta, 2\pi]. \tag{16}$$

The net specific energy change over the illuminated portion of the orbit becomes

$$\Delta\varepsilon_{\text{lit}} = a_0 r \cos^2\beta \left[\int_0^{\pi-\delta} \sin(\beta - \theta)\, d\theta + \int_{\pi+\delta}^{2\pi} \sin(\beta - \theta)\, d\theta\right]. \tag{17}$$

Using the full-orbit cancellation result, this may be written more compactly as minus the contribution from the shadowed arc,

$$\Delta\varepsilon_{\text{lit}} = -a_0 r \cos^2\beta \int_{\pi-\delta}^{\pi+\delta} \sin(\beta - \theta)\, d\theta. \tag{18}$$

Evaluating the integral gives

$$\int_{\pi-\delta}^{\pi+\delta} \sin(\beta - \theta)\, d\theta = 2\sin\beta\, \sin\delta, \tag{19}$$

and hence

$$\Delta\varepsilon_{\text{lit}} = -2a_0 r \cos^2\beta\, \sin\beta\, \sin\delta. \tag{20}$$

Equation (20) shows explicitly that eclipse does not merely reduce the SRP magnitude; it breaks the passive cancellation by removing a finite interval of orbital phase from the work integral. The sign of the net energy change is therefore controlled by the sign of $-\sin\beta$. In this 2D midnight-orbit idealisation,

$$\Delta\varepsilon_{\text{lit}} > 0 \qquad \Longleftrightarrow \qquad \sin\beta < 0. \tag{21}$$

A finite branch of pitch angles therefore exists for which eclipse suppresses unfavourable work more strongly than favourable work, leaving a positive residual contribution to the one-orbit SRP work balance and hence a positive one-orbit energy change.

Within this reduced 2D midnight-orbit model, the magnitude of the one-orbit energy gain is maximised by maximising $-\sin\beta\cos^2\beta$, which gives

$$\sin^2\beta = \frac{1}{3}, \tag{22}$$

with the positive-gain branch

$$\beta^\star = -\arcsin\left(\frac{1}{\sqrt{3}}\right) \approx -35.3°. \tag{23}$$

This result is used here only to show that the eclipse-modulated work imbalance is not marginal or accidental in the reduced geometry. It is not claimed to be a design optimum for the full propagated 3D system, whose geometry, illumination history, drag losses, and coupled element evolution are substantially richer.

3.4. Dependence on orbital geometry

The reduced mechanism is intrinsically phase-selective and therefore strongly dependent on orbital geometry. In the full problem, the local time of descending node (LTDN), the Sun-relative orientation of the orbital plane, and the fixed sail attitude together determine which parts of the orbit are illuminated, which are shadowed, and how the SRP work distribution is sampled. The sign and magnitude of the orbit-integrated SRP contribution therefore depend on whether eclipse preferentially removes unfavourable or favourable work phases.

The midnight case is analytically useful because the eclipse is centred on the anti-solar point and the resulting shadow interval is symmetric in orbital phase, allowing the effect of selective gating to be shown in closed form. Away from this limiting geometry, the illuminated and shadowed arcs shift relative to the SRP work distribution, and the balance between positive and negative transverse work changes accordingly. Net semi-major-axis growth is therefore expected only over restricted regions of the full parameter space.

Crucially, the same phase-dependent forcing that produces a favourable one-orbit SRP work imbalance need not produce shape-preserving orbit raising. Gauss' variational equations imply that the detailed phasing of F_R and F_T can simultaneously drive changes in eccentricity and related orbital geometry, while out-of-plane forcing in the full 3D problem affects inclination and node. A positive orbit-averaged SRP work contribution is therefore not equivalent to uniform upward translation of the orbit. In the propagated cases examined later, the same eclipse-biased phasing that produces transient semi-major-axis gain can coexist with eccentricity growth, altered perigee and apogee behaviour, and ultimately degradation of the gain regime.

3.5. Transient nature of the mechanism

The reduced analysis establishes only that eclipse can bias the one-orbit SRP work balance in favour of net energy gain for restricted geometries. It does not establish persistence, monotonic orbit raising, or long-horizon robustness once the full coupled dynamics are restored. The propagated 3D results therefore test whether this favourable work asymmetry survives in realistic near-polar LEO motion, and how it breaks down through coupled changes in eccentricity, drag exposure, and Sun-relative geometry; these longer-horizon effects are examined in Section 7.

Table 1
Required inclination to maintain Sun-synchronous orbits (SSO) for circular orbits ($e = 0$) at selected altitudes.

Altitude (km)	Required Inclination (°)
600	97.92
700	98.04
800	98.17
900	98.31

Table 2
Baseline parameters used for the representative gain-case propagation and local mechanism analysis.

Parameter	Value
Initial altitude, h_0	700 km
Initial inclination, i_0	98.17°
Initial eccentricity, e_0	1×10^{-4}
Spacecraft mass, m	10 kg
Sail area, A	100 m^2
Area-to-mass ratio, A/m	10 m^2 kg^{-1}
Reflectivity coefficient, C_r	1.7
Drag coefficient, C_D	2.2

4. Dynamical model and assumptions

This study considers a bounded orbital-dynamics problem in near-polar low Earth orbit (LEO) intended to isolate the short-horizon interaction between solar radiation pressure (SRP), eclipse timing, atmospheric drag, and J_2-driven nodal precession. The emphasis is on whether a sail with inertially fixed orientation can exhibit short-horizon semi-major-axis growth while remaining close to Sun-synchronous orbital geometry.

A Sun-synchronous orbit (SSO) is desirable because it maintains a predictable Sun-relative geometry while allowing the orbital plane to precess with the apparent annual motion of the Sun [31]. For near-circular LEO, this requires a secular right ascension of the ascending node (RAAN) precession rate of approximately

$$\frac{d\Omega}{dt} \approx 0.986^\circ/\text{day}, \tag{24}$$

which is primarily supplied by Earth's oblateness through the J_2 perturbation. The corresponding nodal precession rate is [31]

$$\dot{\Omega} = -\frac{3}{2} J_2 \left(\frac{R_E}{a(1-e^2)} \right)^2 \sqrt{\frac{\mu}{a^3}} \cos i. \tag{25}$$

For circular orbits ($e = 0$) in the altitude range considered here, the inclination required to satisfy Eq. (24) is close to 98°, as summarised in Table 1.

In the present work, the sail orientation is prescribed as inertially fixed over the time horizons of interest, and no active steering law is applied during propagation. This contrasts with actively steered sails [33, 34] and with active momentum management approaches such as those developed for Solar Cruiser [35, 36]. The fixed-attitude assumption is deliberate: it allows the orbital consequences of a fixed force geometry to be isolated directly, without introducing control-law dependence into the interpretation of the results. At the same time, it imposes an important limitation. As the orbital plane precesses and the Sun-relative geometry evolves, the orientation of the sail with respect to both the Sun and the local orbital frame cannot remain optimal indefinitely. Any favourable energy-transfer regime must therefore be understood as geometry-bounded and transient rather than as a permanently sustained operating mode.

The evolution of the orbit under weak non-Keplerian perturbations is interpreted using the Gauss Variational Equations (GVEs) [31, 32]. Writing the perturbing acceleration vector $\vec{F}$ in the local orbital frame as radial (F_R), transverse (F_T), and normal (F_N) components, the orbital-element evolution is given by

$$\frac{da}{dt} = \frac{2a^2}{h} \left[e \sin\theta \, F_R + (1 + e\cos\theta) \, F_T \right], \tag{26}$$

$$\frac{de}{dt} = \frac{\mu}{h} \left[\sin\theta \, F_R + \left(\cos\theta + \frac{e + \cos\theta}{1 + e\cos\theta} \right) F_T \right] \tag{27}$$

$$\frac{di}{dt} = \frac{r\cos u}{h} F_N, \tag{28}$$

$$\frac{d\Omega}{dt} = \frac{r\sin u}{h \sin i} F_N, \tag{29}$$

where $h = \sqrt{\mu a(1-e^2)}$ is the specific angular momentum, $r = a(1-e^2)/(1+e\cos\theta)$ is the instantaneous orbital radius, θ is the true anomaly, and $u = \omega + \theta$ is the argument of latitude. A detailed derivation of the GVEs is given by Vallado [31].

These expressions clarify the role of each perturbing component. In near-circular LEO, semi-major-axis growth is driven primarily by the in-plane force, especially the transverse component F_T, whereas inclination i and RAAN Ω evolve through the normal component F_N. Since Sun-synchronicity relies on the secular J_2-driven nodal precession described above, additional out-of-plane forcing should remain small if the orbit is to stay close to the desired SSO geometry.

This creates the central geometrical tension of the present study. To obtain semi-major-axis growth, the sail must produce a favourable in-plane force with a strong transverse projection, while remaining close to SSO requires the normal component F_N to stay limited. Because the sail orientation is fixed in inertial space, the Sun-relative cone angle and the orbital-frame force decomposition drift as the orbit evolves, so any favourable geometry is expected to persist only over a bounded interval.

The force model retained for this study is intentionally simple and is chosen to isolate the mechanism of interest rather than to maximise environmental fidelity. The translational dynamics include central gravity, Earth's oblateness through the J_2 term, solar radiation pressure, eclipse shadowing, and atmospheric drag. No Earth albedo model is included.

Solar radiation pressure

The SRP model is based on photon momentum transfer to a reflective flat plate [13]. For an idealised square sail with cone angle α relative to the Sun line, the force magnitude follows the familiar $\cos^2\alpha$ dependence for a flat-plate sail (see 13, Ch. 2). In the implementation used here, the SRP acceleration is written as

$$\mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{SRP}} = \frac{P_{1\ \mathrm{AU}}\, A\, C_r}{mc} \cos^2\alpha\, \hat{\mathbf{r}}, \tag{30}$$

where $P_{1\ \mathrm{AU}}$ denotes the solar radiation flux at one astronomical unit [37], A is the sail area, C_r is the reflectivity coefficient, m is the spacecraft mass, and $\hat{\mathbf{r}}$ is the unit vector from the spacecraft to the Sun. The SRP acceleration is evaluated in the inertial frame and then resolved into the orbital frame for interpretation through the GVEs.

Eclipses are modelled using a binary conical shadow geometry. The spacecraft is treated as illuminated when it lies outside the Earth's umbral cone and fully shadowed when it lies within it, so that SRP is either applied in full or suppressed entirely. This treatment is sufficient for the present purpose because the paper is concerned primarily with the orbital-phase selectivity of SRP application rather than with resolving penumbral transition details. The shadowed SRP acceleration is therefore written as

$$\mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{SRP}}^{\mathrm{shadowed}} = s \cdot \mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{SRP}}, \tag{31}$$

where

$$s = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{illuminated,} \\ 0, & \text{eclipsed.} \end{cases}$$

This eclipse treatment is central to the present paper because the mechanism of interest depends not only on the magnitude of SRP, but on which orbital arcs remain illuminated and which are removed by shadow.

Atmospheric drag

Atmospheric drag is included because it remains dynamically relevant throughout the altitude range considered, particularly once eccentricity growth lowers perigee and increases local density exposure. The atmospheric density is represented using a piecewise-exponential fit to U.S. Standard Atmosphere (1976) data [38] based on Braeunig's tabulation [39]. Within each altitude interval i, the density is evaluated as

$$\rho(h) = \rho_0^{(i)} \exp\left(-\frac{h - h_0^{(i)}}{H^{(i)}}\right), \tag{32}$$

where $\rho_0^{(i)}$, $h_0^{(i)}$, and $H^{(i)}$ are the reference density, reference altitude, and scale height for that layer.

The aerodynamic model used here is a simple projected-area drag law. Atmospheric rotational velocity is not modelled; the relative flow is taken directly from the spacecraft inertial velocity. The drag acceleration is written as

$$\mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{drag}} = -\frac{1}{2}\, \rho(h)\, v^2\, C_D\, \frac{A_{\mathrm{frontal}}}{m}\, \hat{\mathbf{v}}, \tag{33}$$

where $C_D = 2.2$ is a standard value for satellites in free-molecular flow [31], m is the spacecraft mass, $v = \|\mathbf{v}\|$, and $\hat{\mathbf{v}}$ is the unit vector in the velocity direction. The frontal area A_{frontal} is computed from the projection of the sail surface onto the plane normal to the instantaneous velocity vector, so that the effective drag area varies with the angle between the inertially fixed sail normal and the flow.

The drag model is intentionally simple. Its role in this paper is not to resolve high-fidelity free-molecular aerodynamics, but to capture the dominant loss mechanism opposing SRP-driven energy gain. This is especially important once the orbit departs from circularity, because drag then remains concentrated near perigee and can overtake the orbit-averaged SRP surplus even when early-time semi-major-axis growth is observed.

The assumptions adopted above are sufficient for the present purpose of mechanism isolation and regime mapping. They do not constitute a full validation of passive sail performance over long durations, nor do they resolve all structural, control, or environmental uncertainties relevant to flight operations. Those questions are outside the scope of this section and are addressed only insofar as they affect interpretation of the short-horizon transient dynamics studied in this paper.

Table 3
Summary of the principal modelling assumptions used in the orbital propagations.

Assumption / model element	Implementation used in this study
Attitude treatment	Sail orientation prescribed as inertially fixed over the horizon of interest; no active steering law applied during propagation.
Central gravity	Included as the baseline point-mass Earth gravitational field.
J_2 perturbation	Included to capture Earth oblateness and the associated secular nodal precession required for near-Sun-synchronous behaviour.
Solar radiation pressure (SRP)	Included using a flat-plate sail model with one-sided illumination and force scaling with incidence angle through a cosine-based projection law.
Eclipse model	Included using a conical Earth shadow model that suppresses SRP during eclipse intervals.
Atmospheric drag	Included using a projected-area flat-plate drag law with $C_D = 2.2$.
Density model	Static piecewise-exponential atmospheric density fit based on U.S. Standard Atmosphere (1976) reference data.
Atmospheric co-rotation	Neglected; relative flow taken directly from the spacecraft inertial velocity.
Earth albedo	Omitted.
Orbit regime	Near-circular, near-polar LEO focused on maintaining approximate Sun-synchronous geometry.
Study objective	Controlled mechanism-isolation study of transient gain behaviour, not a full mission-feasibility or flight-operations model.

5. Parameter Space and Metrics

Having defined the governing assumptions and force models, we now specify the parameter space and, critically, the fixed-window metric used to identify the transient gain regime. Because the central question of this paper is whether eclipse-modulated SRP can produce a *temporary* semi-major-axis increase over a bounded horizon, the primary map-based quantity is not the final change in a at the end of the run, and not the long-horizon change over 75 days, but the largest positive excursion above the initial semi-major axis attained at any time within a prescribed analysis window. The aim is therefore to determine whether such transient gain occupies a coherent region of design space, and how narrow or robust that region is.

The primary parameters varied in this study are the local time of the descending node (LTDN), the initial sail orientation, and the initial orbital altitude. LTDN determines the Sun-relative geometry of the orbit and hence the phasing between illuminated arcs, eclipsed arcs, and the SRP work pattern; the initial sail orientation controls the decomposition of SRP into radial, transverse, and normal components; and altitude alters both the drag environment and the baseline Sun-synchronous inclination required through 24. Together, these parameters define the geometry within which the transient gain regime may or may not appear.

In the baseline sweeps, the initial orbit is taken to be near-circular and Sun-synchronous, with inclination selected consistently with the chosen altitude using Table 1. For each case, the sail orientation is prescribed as inertially fixed from the initial epoch onward. Additional sensitivity studies may then be introduced around representative gain and non-gain cases by perturbing the nominal sail orientation, varying atmospheric density through a scalar multiplier, or applying small static orientation offsets to test the fragility of the identified regime.

The parameter-space exploration is intentionally staged. The first sweep is performed over LTDN and initial sail angle at fixed altitude and fixed sail loading, in order to determine whether a connected region of *transient* gain exists at all under the fixed-window metric defined below. Only after this primary map is established are additional altitude cases and uncertainty sweeps introduced.

A fixed analysis horizon is used for consistent comparison between cases. The primary map-based metric is

$$\Delta a_{\max}(T) = \max_{t\in[0,T]} \left(a(t) - a_0\right), \tag{34}$$

with $T = 14$ d in the principal parameter-space sweep. Thus, $\Delta a_{\max,14\mathrm{d}}$ measures the largest positive semi-major-axis excursion above the initial orbit attained *anywhere* within the first 14 days. It is *not* the final value of $a(14\,\mathrm{d}) - a_0$, and it is *not* the net change after the longer 75-day propagation used later to study breakdown. This choice is deliberate: for a transient-gain problem, the physically relevant first question is whether a trajectory ever enters a favourable interval of positive semi-major-axis excursion within a common bounded window, not whether that excursion survives indefinitely.

To support physical interpretation, the fixed-window excursion metric is supplemented by orbit-resolved work diagnostics. In particular, we track the cumulative contribution of SRP and drag to the along-track work budget, since the mechanism proposed in Section 3 is not merely that SRP is present, but that eclipse can selectively retain or suppress SRP work over specific orbital arcs and thereby produce, or fail to produce, a temporary positive excursion in a. For a given perturbing acceleration $\mathbf{a}_p$, the instantaneous specific

power is

$$P_p(t) = \mathbf{a}_p(t) \cdot \mathbf{v}(t), \tag{35}$$

and the associated cumulative specific work over a time interval $[t_1, t_2]$ is

$$W_p(t_1, t_2) = \int_{t_1}^{t_2} \mathbf{a}_p(t) \cdot \mathbf{v}(t)\, dt. \tag{36}$$

In practice, these quantities are evaluated separately for SRP and drag and then accumulated over individual orbits and over the full analysis horizon.

Because the hypothesised mechanism is most naturally interpreted in the orbital frame, we also track the transverse components of the perturbing accelerations. From Eq. (26), the transverse contribution is especially important in near-circular orbits, where it acts most directly on orbital energy and semi-major axis. For this reason, we record both the instantaneous transverse accelerations $F_{T,\mathrm{SRP}}$ and $F_{T,\mathrm{drag}}$, and their orbit-integrated contributions, alongside the full energy-based work budget. These diagnostics are used to distinguish between three physically different situations: cases in which eclipse removes predominantly unfavourable SRP arcs, cases in which eclipse produces little net bias, and cases in which the remaining illuminated arcs are themselves energetically unfavourable.

In addition to semi-major axis, we record the evolution of apogee radius r_a, perigee radius r_p, eccentricity e, inclination i, and right ascension of the ascending node Ω. These quantities are necessary because positive Δa alone does not imply clean whole-orbit raising. In particular, a gain in a may be accompanied by growth in eccentricity, with apogee increasing more strongly than perigee. Since drag remains concentrated near perigee, this distinction is central to understanding why the transient gain regime can disappear even after an initially favourable interval. The coupled evolution of r_a, r_p, and e therefore forms a second layer of interpretation beyond the headline Δa result.

To capture the role of eclipse geometry explicitly, we also record the eclipse state as a binary quantity throughout propagation, together with the eclipse fraction of each orbit. This allows the work budget to be partitioned orbit-by-orbit into illuminated and shadowed segments. In representative cases, these diagnostics are later plotted against true anomaly so that the reader can see directly which orbital arcs contribute positive SRP work, which contribute negative SRP work, and which are removed by eclipse. This is an important distinction: the paper does not argue merely that eclipse reduces SRP, but that eclipse can alter the sign balance of orbit-averaged SRP work.

On the basis of the fixed-horizon metric $\Delta a_{\max}(T)$, each simulation is assigned to one of three qualitative classes:

- **Gain case:** $\Delta a_{\max}(T) > 0$, indicating that the trajectory attains a positive semi-major-axis excursion at some point within the window;
- **Neutral case:** $\Delta a_{\max}(T) \approx 0$, indicating that no meaningful positive excursion is attained within the window;
- **Decay case:** cases for which $a(t) - a_0$ remains non-positive throughout the window, so that $\Delta a_{\max}(T)$ is zero or numerically negligible and the trajectory is effectively monotone non-gaining over that interval.

These labels are descriptive rather than ontological. In particular, "gain" here means *transient gain within the prescribed window*, not sustained long-horizon orbit raising; likewise, the strongest gain cell in the map is the case with the largest $\Delta a_{\max,14\mathrm{d}}$, not necessarily the most favourable long-horizon trajectory once eccentricity growth and drag accumulation are taken into account.

For representative cases drawn from each class, we additionally identify a transient gain window from the cumulative SRP and drag work curves. This secondary diagnostic is used later to distinguish early favourable behaviour from the subsequent drag-dominated breakdown phase. It is therefore interpretive rather than classificatory: the parameter-space map itself is defined only by $\Delta a_{\max,14\mathrm{d}}$.

The minimum set of diagnostics recorded for each run is therefore as follows: instantaneous SRP and drag accelerations, their transverse components, eclipse state, classical orbital elements, cumulative SRP and drag work, orbit-by-orbit eclipse fraction, and the evolution of a, r_a, and r_p. This choice is deliberate. The present paper is a mechanism and regime-mapping study, so the recorded metrics must do more than rank cases numerically: they must also explain why a given case gains, remains neutral, or decays.

The results that follow therefore proceed in three steps. First, the fixed-window metric $\Delta a_{\max,14\mathrm{d}}$ is used to identify where transient gain does and does not occur in parameter space. Second, orbit-resolved work budgets are used to test whether eclipse causally biases the SRP work balance in those cases. Third, apogee, perigee, eccentricity, and cumulative drag/SRP comparisons are used to explain why a case that exhibits transient gain over 14 days need not remain favourable over longer horizons.

6. Existence and Mechanism of the Transient Gain Regime

This section addresses four questions in sequence: whether a bounded transient-gain region exists at 700 km, whether eclipse is causally responsible for it, how that causality appears in the orbit-resolved SRP work budget, and why the representative gain case should still be interpreted as transient rather than sustained. Because the paper is concerned with *transient* gain, the map-based metric used here is the maximum semi-major-axis increase attained within the first 14 days, not the final Δa at the end of the run.

Figure 2 presents the fixed-window map of maximum semi-major-axis increase at 700 km as a function of LTDN and

initial pitch angle. A single dominant positive lobe appears over approximately LTDN 9.0 to 14.75 h and pitch 0° to 43.4°, with its strongest cell at LTDN 12.266 h and pitch 24.8°, where the trajectory reaches a maximum Δa of approximately +20.07 km. Two much smaller retrograde-pitch clusters also appear, but their gains remain below 0.14 km and are negligible relative to the main lobe. Overall, only 89 of 900 sampled cells ($\sim$ 10%) exhibit positive transient SMA increase, so non-gain behaviour dominates most of the map.

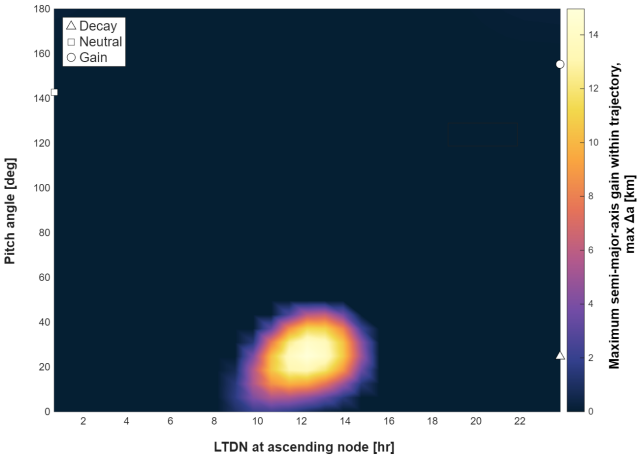


Figure 2: Maximum semi-major axis change (Δa) at 700 km as a function of LTDN and sail pitch angle, showing a localised region of net orbital energy gain with dominant decay outcome in the surrounding space.

The restricted extent of the positive region indicates that the effect is geometry-selective rather than a generic passive orbit-raising tendency.

Three representative 700 km cases are used throughout the remainder of the section: a gain case at RAAN 285.5°, LTDN 12.27 h, and pitch 24.8°; a neutral case at RAAN 111.7°, LTDN 0.68 h, and pitch 142.8°; and a decay case at RAAN 99.3°, LTDN 23.85 h, and pitch 155.2°. The gain case reaches a maximum $\Delta a \approx +20.07$ km at approximately day 26.5, but later declines to $\Delta a \approx -13.42$ km by day 75; the decay case loses SMA monotonically and re-enters by day 42.8. These cases are used to separate bounded existence from mechanism.

The most direct causal test is to compare the representative gain case with and without eclipse while holding all other initial conditions and model assumptions fixed. Figure 3 shows that the short-horizon outcome reverses under that single change. By day 14, the eclipse-on case reaches $\Delta a \approx +10.31$ km, whereas the eclipse-off counterpart has fallen to $\Delta a \approx -47.75$ km, a separation of approximately 58.06 km. Over the full 75-day propagation, the eclipse-on case survives to the end of the run with final $\Delta a \approx -13.42$ km, whereas the eclipse-off case re-enters. The gain case is therefore not simply SRP-favourable in a generic sense; its transient improvement depends on eclipse.

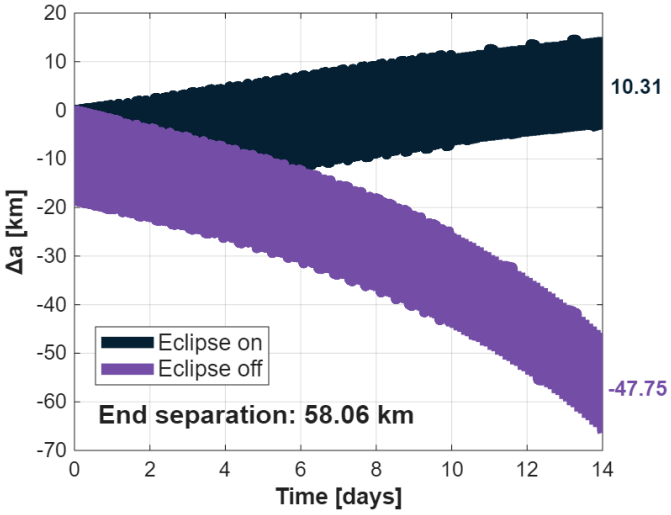


Figure 3: Comparison of semi-major-axis evolution with eclipse on and off for the representative 700 km gain case, showing that the favourable transient behaviour depends directly on eclipse: with eclipse on, the case reaches $\Delta a \approx +10.31$ km by day 14, whereas the eclipse-off counterpart has already fallen to $\Delta a \approx -47.75$ km.

The eclipse-on/off comparison establishes causality, but not the orbit-scale mechanism. Figure 4 addresses that mechanism by plotting the instantaneous SRP specific power, $\mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{SRP}} \cdot \mathbf{v}$, over one periapsis-to-periapsis orbit for the representative gain, neutral, and decay cases, together with the eclipse interval and a dashed no-eclipse reference. In the gain case, eclipse falls predominantly on a would-be negative-power arc: 85.7% of eclipsed samples correspond to negative no-eclipse SRP power, and by integrated magnitude eclipse suppresses roughly $-860\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ of harmful SRP work while removing only about $+15\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ of beneficial work. In the neutral and decay cases, the sign structure reverses: 95.2% and 85.7% of eclipsed samples respectively correspond to would-be *positive* SRP power, so eclipse suppresses the recovery arc instead. The mechanism is therefore sign-selective: the outcome depends on which branch of the SRP-power cycle is removed by shadow.

Figure 4 therefore identifies the mechanism at the instantaneous level: eclipse changes the sign of the orbit-integrated SRP contribution by removing different branches of the SRP-power cycle in different geometries.

Figure 5 shows the same effect in cumulative form. In the gain case, the eclipse-on orbit closes with cumulative SRP specific work of $+799.29\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$, compared with $-9.69\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ for the no-eclipse reference. In the neutral and decay cases, the eclipse-on end values are instead $-665.25\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ and $-857.93\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$, while the corresponding no-eclipse references end near zero at $-4.81\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ and $-53.90\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$. The cumulative view therefore confirms the sign-selective interpretation inferred from Figure 4: eclipse enhances the one-orbit SRP balance only in the gain geometry and degrades it in the neutral and decay geometries.

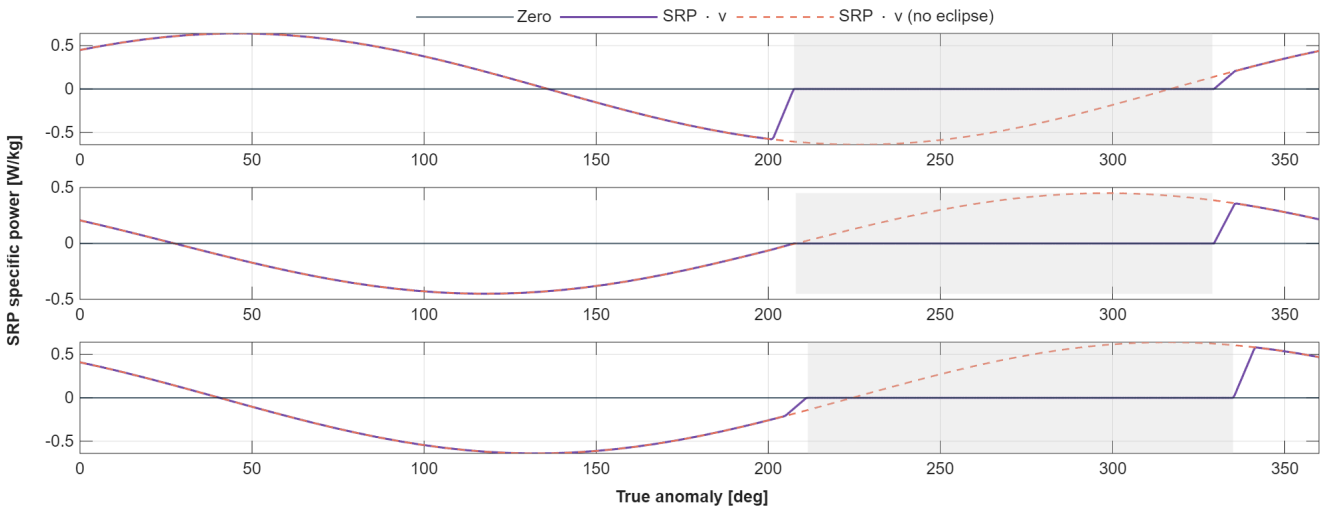


Figure 4: Instantaneous SRP specific power, $\mathbf{a}_{\mathrm{SRP}} \cdot \mathbf{v}$, over one periapsis-to-periapsis orbit for the representative gain, neutral, and decay cases. The shaded interval marks eclipse, and the dashed curve shows the no-eclipse reference. In the gain case, eclipse suppresses a predominantly negative-power arc; in the neutral and decay cases, it instead suppresses a predominantly positive-power arc.

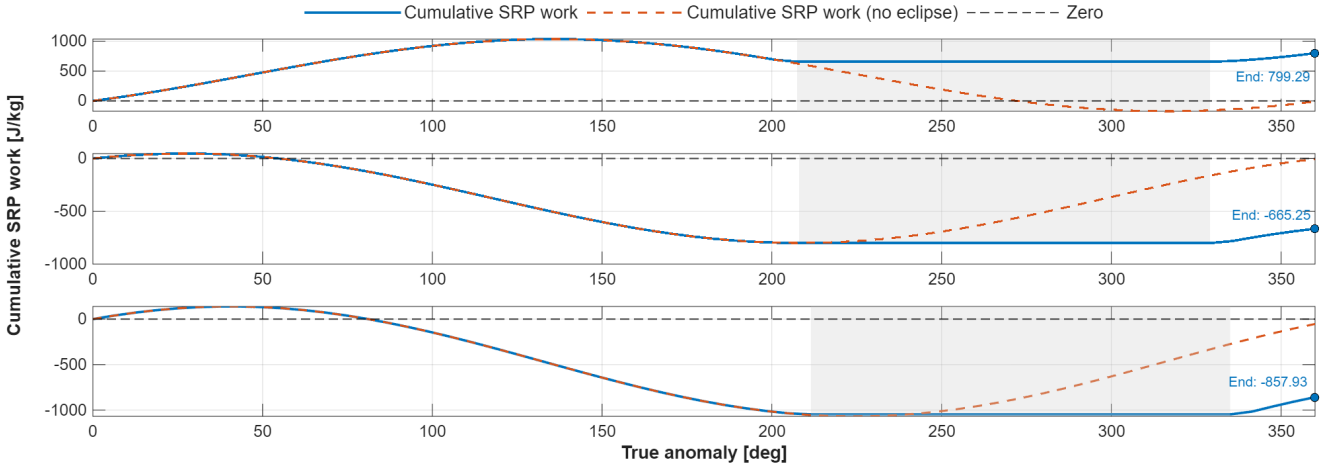


Figure 5: Cumulative SRP specific work over one periapsis-to-periapsis orbit for the representative gain, neutral, and decay cases, with dashed no-eclipse references for comparison. The eclipse-on end values are $+799.29\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$, $-665.25\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$, and $-857.93\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ respectively, showing that eclipse enhances the SRP budget only in the gain geometry and worsens it in the neutral and decay geometries.

The representative gain case also confirms an important limitation of the mechanism. Although the trajectory attains a substantial positive semi-major-axis excursion within the analysed window, that behaviour is not equivalent to clean or sustained whole-orbit raising over longer horizons. The detailed longer-horizon evolution of the gain case is examined in Section 7.

Taken together, the results in this section establish three points. First, a bounded transient-gain region exists at 700 km in LTDN–pitch space. Second, eclipse is causally decisive: removing it reverses the short-horizon outcome of the representative gain case. Third, the orbit-resolved SRP budget identifies the mechanism: eclipse helps only when it removes a negative-power branch and harms when it removes a positive-recovery branch. The representative gain case is therefore physically real, but not a claim of sustained orbit raising.

7. Coupled Orbital Evolution and Breakdown of the Gain Regime

The representative gain trajectory must now be examined over longer horizons to determine what the early increase in semi-major axis actually corresponds to dynamically, and why that favourable behaviour does not persist. The central result is linear: the early increase in a is real, but it is produced mainly by apogee pumping rather than by a clean

Table 4
Long-horizon summary of the representative 700 km gain case over the 75-day propagation. The case corresponds to altitude 700 km, RAAN 285.5°, pitch 24.8°, LTDN 12.266 hr, inclination 98.2°, $e_0 = 10^{-4}$, sail area 100 m^2, mass 10 kg, $C_r = 1.7$, and $C_d = 2.2$.

Quantity	Initial	Peak / Minimum	Final
Semi-major axis, a [km]	7078.137	7098.211 (max, day 26.50)	7064.717
Net semi-major-axis change, $\Delta a_{75\mathrm{d}}$ [km]	−13.420		
Apogee altitude [km]	700.709	864.548 (max, day 39.50)	775.102
Perigee altitude [km]	699.293	546.370 (min, day 42.17)	598.059
Eccentricity, e	1.000×10^{-4}	2.176×10^{-2} (max, day 40.72)	1.253×10^{-2}
Cumulative SRP work at day 75 [MJ]	+6.054		
Cumulative drag work at day 75 [MJ]	−6.030		
Cumulative total work at day 75 [MJ]	+0.024		
Work ratio at day 75, $\lvert W_{\mathrm{drag}}\rvert / \lvert W_{\mathrm{SRP}}\rvert$	0.9961		

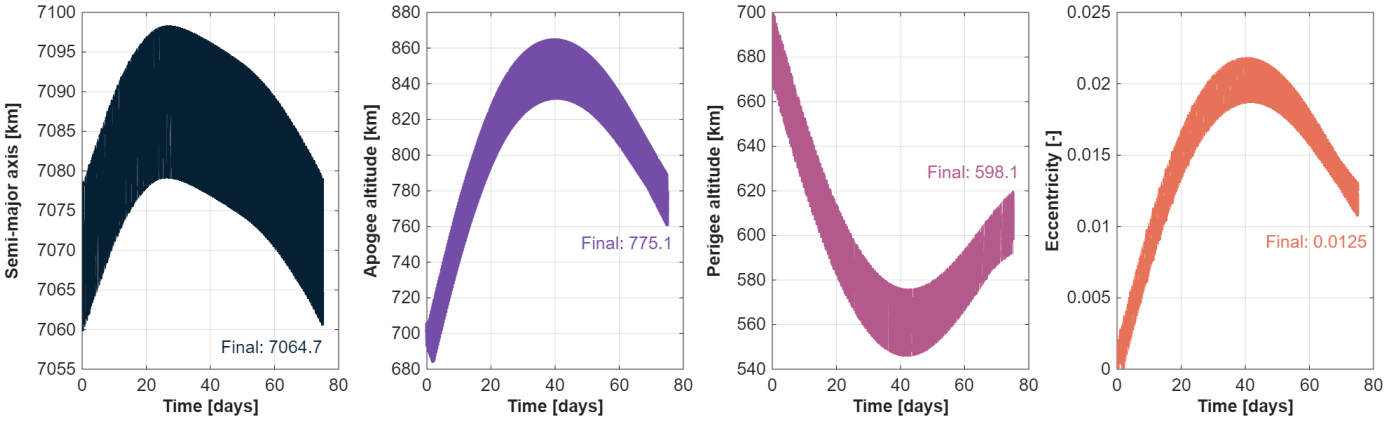


Figure 6: Long-horizon evolution of orbital elements for the representative 700 km gain case, showing non-monotonic semi-major-axis evolution, strong apogee growth, perigee erosion, and eccentricity increase over the 75-day propagation.

upward translation of the whole orbit; this increases eccentricity, lowers perigee, concentrates drag loss near perigee, and eventually causes the late-window orbit-averaged energy balance to turn negative.

Figure 6 makes the first part of that breakdown visible directly. For the representative 700 km gain case introduced in Section 6, the 75-day histories of a, apogee altitude, perigee altitude, and eccentricity show that the orbit is not lifted uniformly. Instead, apogee grows much more strongly than perigee is preserved, so the early gain develops together with a progressive departure from circularity.

The semi-major axis begins at $a_0 = 7{,}078.137$ km, rises early, reaches a maximum of 7,098.211 km, and then declines for the remainder of the propagation to a final value below its initial level. The behaviour is therefore explicitly non-monotonic: there is a finite interval of positive excursion, but not sustained whole-horizon orbit raising. In other words, the short-horizon gain is real, yet it does not remain self-maintaining over the full 75-day window.

The apogee–perigee split shows how that breakdown develops. Apogee rises strongly and remains elevated, whereas perigee falls substantially and remains depressed. At the same time, the eccentricity grows from an initially near-circular value to an order 10^{-2} state and relaxes only partially thereafter. The key point is therefore geometric rather than merely descriptive: the early increase in a is achieved primarily by stretching the orbit, not by lifting it uniformly.

The physical consequence is that drag loss becomes progressively concentrated near perigee, where the atmosphere is densest. This is the clearest breakdown pathway visible in the long-horizon outputs: the same evolution that produces the early gain also creates a lower-perigee, more eccentric orbit that is increasingly vulnerable to atmospheric loss. No stronger claim than that is needed here.

The cumulative work budget in Figure 7 must be read carefully. Over the full 75-day window, cumulative SRP work remains slightly larger than cumulative drag work, so the cumulative total is still marginally positive by day 75. That does *not* mean the regime is still strengthening at late times. It means only that an earlier accumulated surplus has not yet been fully erased. By the end of the run, that surplus is nearly exhausted, with $|W_{\mathrm{drag}}|/|W_{\mathrm{SRP}}| \approx 0.9961$.

Table 5
Early-versus-late comparison for the representative 700 km gain case. The orbit-averaged work budget uses 20% windows (first and last 218 of 1090 total orbits), whereas the SRP force-decomposition comparison uses 10% windows (first and last 109 orbits), matching the conventions used in the corresponding figure-generation scripts.

Metric	Early window	Late window	Late / Early
Orbit-averaged work budget (20% windows; 218 orbits each)			
Mean SRP work [kJ/orbit]	+7.91	+2.71	0.343
Mean drag work [kJ/orbit]	−5.01	−4.55	0.908
Mean net work [kJ/orbit]	+2.89	−1.84	—
SRP force decomposition (10% windows; 109 orbits each)			
Orbit-mean $\lvert F_T \rvert$ [N]	3.52×10^{-4}	5.91×10^{-5}	0.207
Orbit-mean $\lvert F_N \rvert$ [N]	5.89×10^{-7}	1.50×10^{-4}	5.36

The more revealing diagnostic is therefore the orbit-averaged early-versus-late comparison in Figure 8. Early in the run, the mean SRP contribution exceeds the mean drag loss, so the per-orbit balance is positive. Late in the run, the mean SRP contribution has collapsed while drag remains large, and the orbit-averaged net balance becomes negative. The breakdown is therefore already present on a local per-orbit basis even though the full-window cumulative total remains slightly positive.

The correct long-horizon interpretation is therefore a timescale split: the trajectory retains a small cumulative surplus from its earlier favourable phase, but its late-time orbit-averaged balance has already turned negative. The regime is not sustained; it is being unwound.

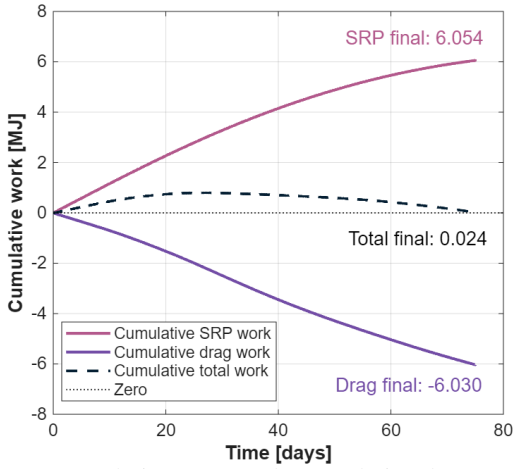


Figure 7: Cumulative SRP work, cumulative drag work, and cumulative total work for the representative 700 km gain case over 75 days. The cumulative budget remains positive throughout the analysed window, but only narrowly: by day 75, cumulative drag has nearly caught up to cumulative SRP.

The physical picture is therefore one of temporary outperformance, not eliminated decay. Eclipse-modulated SRP produces an early advantage, but the resulting orbital distortion lowers perigee, increases eccentricity, and makes subsequent drag losses harder to offset. The mechanism delays deterioration for a finite interval; it does not remove the long-horizon tendency toward decay.

The longer-term weakening is also consistent with the force-decomposition framework introduced in Chapter 4. There, using the Gauss Variational Equations, we argued that semi-major-axis growth depends primarily on maintaining a favourable in-plane force, especially a strong transverse component F_T, while avoiding excessive projection into the normal direction F_N, which does not contribute directly to useful in-plane energy growth. The representative gain case shows a major redistribution of the SRP force between these channels. As shown in Figure 9, the orbit-mean magnitude of the transverse component decreases from approximately 3.529×10^{-4} N early in the mission to approximately 7.312×10^{-5} N late in the mission, a reduction by a factor of about 4.8. Over the same early-to-late comparison, the orbit-mean magnitude of the normal component increases from approximately 3.224×10^{-5} N to approximately 1.727×10^{-4} N, an increase by a factor of about 5.4.

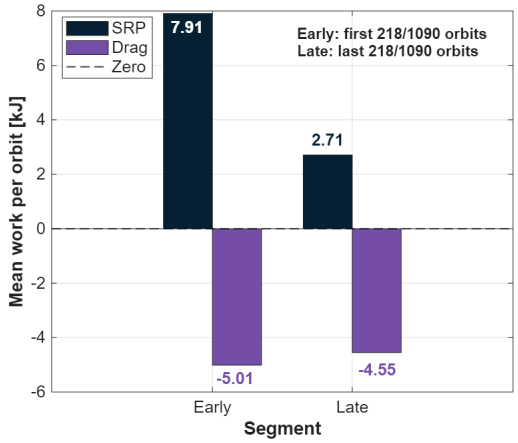


Figure 8: Early-versus-late orbit-averaged work budget for the representative 700 km gain case. The mean SRP contribution collapses strongly between the early and late windows, while the drag penalty remains large, producing a negative late-window net balance.

This redistribution of SRP force is not secondary bookkeeping. Because the sail orientation is fixed in inertial space while the orbit evolves, the SRP force becomes progressively less well aligned with the favourable local RT-plane direction. The transverse component weakens strongly, the

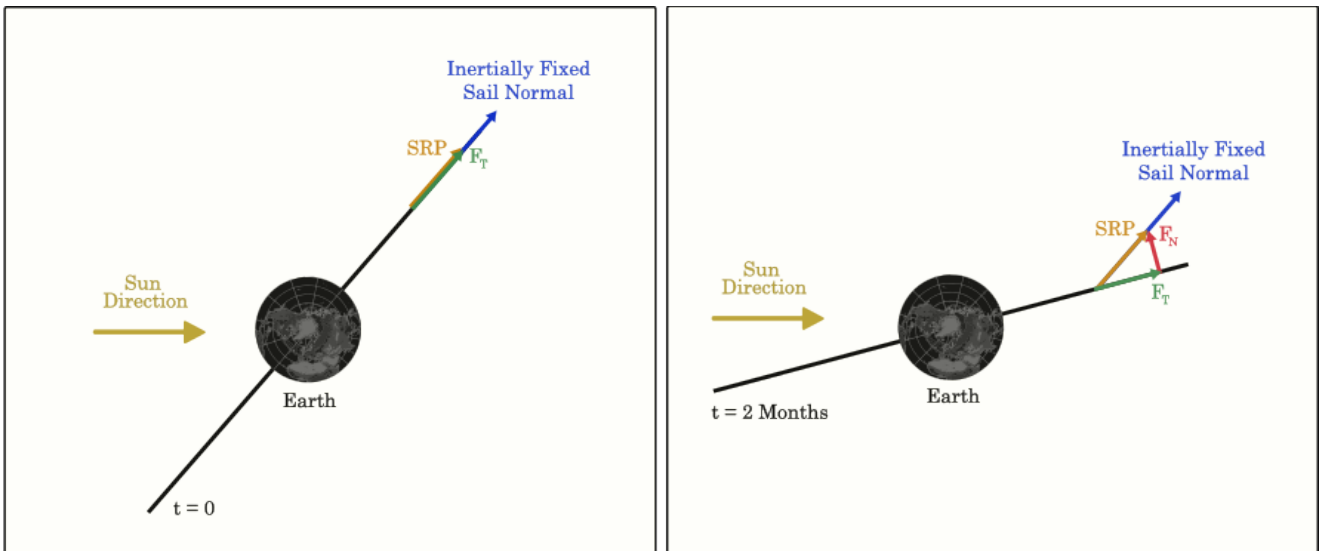


Figure 10: Illustration of SRP projection drift for an inertially fixed, spin-stabilised sail in a precessing near-polar orbit. At $t = 0$ (left), the fixed sail normal produces a favourable transverse SRP component F_T. After two months (right), orbital precession changes the Sun-relative orbital geometry, so the same inertially fixed attitude projects less favourably into the local frame, with reduced F_T and larger normal contribution F_N. This geometric drift contributes to the breakdown of the transient gain regime over longer timescales.

normal component becomes relatively larger on an early-to-late basis, and the contribution to $\dot{a}$ correspondingly degrades. This geometrical drift is therefore a second breakdown pathway, alongside the drag concentration caused by perigee erosion.

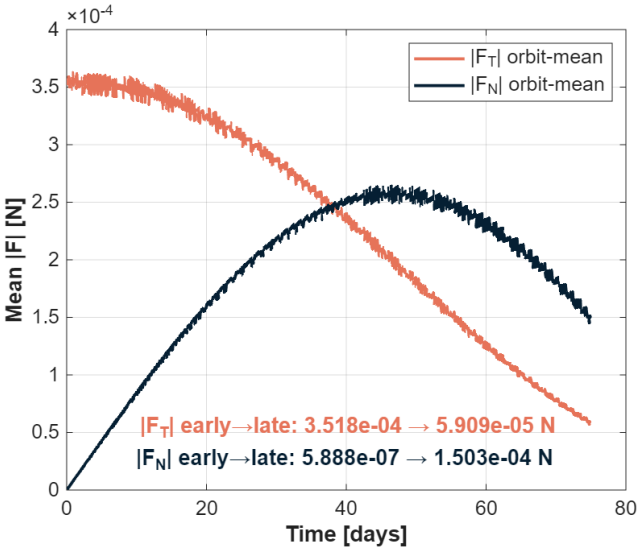


Figure 9: Orbit-mean SRP force decomposition for the representative 700 km gain case. The favourable transverse component weakens strongly over time, while the normal component becomes much larger on an early-to-late basis, indicating a substantial redistribution away from the most useful in-plane forcing direction.

Taken together, the results in this section resolve the apparent tension between early gain and later decay. The mechanism established in Section 6 is real, but it is front-loaded and self-limiting. Early positive Δa is achieved mainly through apogee pumping rather than clean whole-orbit lifting; that evolution increases eccentricity and lowers perigee, which concentrates drag loss, while the fixed inertial sail orientation also causes the SRP force to drift away from the most favourable transverse direction. The late-time orbit-averaged balance therefore turns negative even though a small cumulative surplus from the earlier phase remains by day 75. The regime does not fail abruptly; it progressively exhausts the margin that created it.

8. Robustness and sensitivity of the gain-anchor case

To assess whether the identified short-horizon gain behaviour is a numerically isolated point or instead occupies a finite bounded neighborhood, a set of local sensitivity sweeps was carried out about the same representative gain-anchor geometry over a fixed 14-day analysis window. In all cases, the response metric is the maximum semi-major-axis increase attained within that window,

$$\Delta a_{\max,14\mathrm{d}} = \max_{t\in[0,14\,\mathrm{d}]} \left(a(t) - a_0\right), \tag{37}$$

expressed in kilometres. This is therefore not the final semi-major-axis change at day 14, but the largest positive excursion relative to the initial orbit attained at any time within the first 14 days. The common reference geometry for all three sweeps is defined by $\Omega = 285.5°$, LTDN $= 12.266176$ hr, nominal pitch 24.8°, zero roll offset, a 10×10 m sail, and $A/m = 10\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$, with the same configuration propagated at both 700 km and 800 km. The corresponding nominal responses are $\Delta a_{\max,14\mathrm{d}} = 14.958$ km

at 700 km and 33.937 km at 800 km. The 800 km curves should therefore be interpreted as a same-geometry altitude comparison rather than as a separately re-optimised gain anchor.

8.1. Static roll sensitivity

At the same time, the envelope remains clearly bounded at both altitudes. As the roll magnitude increases beyond roughly 20°, the attainable gain decreases steadily, showing that the eclipse-biased work surplus is still alignment-sensitive. The important additional result is that the sensitivity weakens markedly at higher altitude. At 700 km, offsets of ±45° retain only a small fraction of the zero-roll peak, whereas at 800 km the same offsets still preserve roughly half of the nominal response. In absolute terms, the 800 km case with a 45° roll offset still produces a gain comparable to the zero-roll nominal case at 700 km. The sweep remains mildly asymmetric about zero, consistent with the present one-sided SRP illumination model, but the dominant result is not the asymmetry itself; it is that the admissible roll envelope broadens substantially once the drag environment is relaxed.

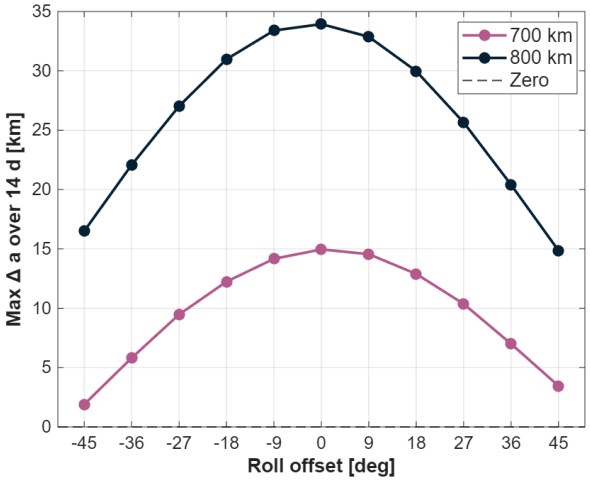


Figure 11: Sensitivity of the 14-day maximum semi-major-axis increase, $\Delta a_{\mathrm{max,14d}}$, to static roll offset about the gain-anchor attitude, shown for the same reference geometry propagated at 700 km and 800 km. The common geometry is $\Omega = 285.5°$, LTDN = 12.266176 hr, pitch 24.8°, zero roll offset, and $A/m = 10\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$. The response peaks at zero roll at both altitudes, but the bounded alignment envelope is substantially broader at 800 km.

8.2. Sensitivity to atmospheric density level

Figure 12 shows the effect of scaling the atmospheric density model by a constant multiplicative factor while holding the gain-anchor geometry fixed at both 700 km and 800 km. At 700 km, the nominal atmosphere case (1×) gives $\Delta a_{\mathrm{max,14d}} = 14.96$ km, which increases to 28.59 km at 0.5× density and 34.89 km at 0.25×. Increasing density, however, suppresses the gain completely at this altitude: at 2× and 4× density, $\Delta a_{\mathrm{max,14d}} = 0$. At 800 km, by contrast, the same sweep remains positive throughout the full tested range, with 33.94 km at nominal density, 26.49 km at 2×, and 10.25 km even at 4× density.

This sweep shows most clearly that drag is the dominant bounding mechanism, but it also shows that the location of the drag-limited boundary depends strongly on altitude. At 700 km, the short-horizon semi-major-axis increase exists only while the eclipse-biased SRP work surplus exceeds the accumulated drag losses; once the atmosphere is strengthened sufficiently, the drag penalty dominates from the outset and the semi-major axis never rises above its initial value within the 14-day window. At 800 km, however, the same mechanism remains much more resilient: increased density degrades the gain substantially, but does not eliminate it across the tested range. The most defensible interpretation is therefore not that the regime is uniformly fragile, but that it is strongly altitude-dependent and can lie either near or well away from the drag-limited boundary depending on orbital height.

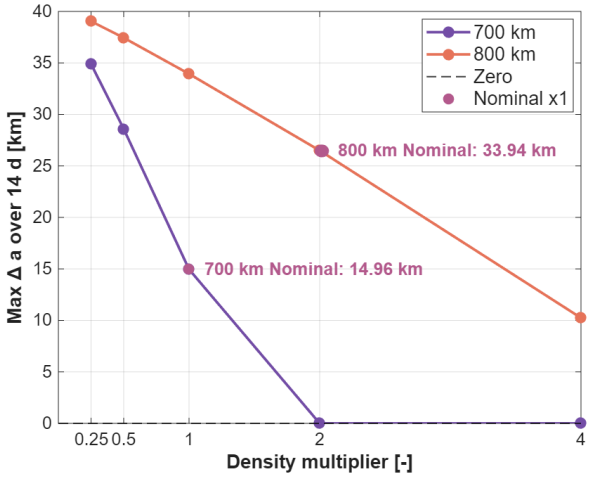


Figure 12: Sensitivity of the 14-day maximum semi-major-axis increase, $\Delta a_{\mathrm{max,14d}}$, to a multiplicative density scaling applied about the same gain-anchor geometry at 700 km and 800 km. Reduced density strengthens the short-horizon gain at both altitudes. Increased density suppresses the 700 km response completely by 2× nominal density, whereas the 800 km case remains positive throughout the tested range, showing that the drag-limited boundary shifts substantially with altitude.

8.3. Sensitivity to area-to-mass ratio

Figure 13 shows the response to varying area-to-mass ratio while keeping the spacecraft mass fixed at 10 kg. The square sail side length is varied from 5 to 15 m, corresponding to A/m values from 2.5 to 22.5 $\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$. At 700 km, the response is non-monotonic. Starting from low A/m, the maximum short-horizon gain rises from 4.17 km at $A/m = 2.5\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$ to the nominal 14.96 km at $A/m = 10\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$, then reaches a broad maximum of 17.92 km at $A/m =$

$14.4\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$, before declining slightly at larger sail sizes. At 800 km, by contrast, the response remains monotonic over the full sampled range, rising from 8.54 km at $A/m = 2.5\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$ to 71.61 km at $A/m = 22.5\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$, with no roll-over yet visible.

The altitude split again changes the interpretation. At 700 km, the non-monotonicity shows that increasing sail size does not produce indefinite improvement: larger A/m strengthens SRP, but it also strengthens drag and modifies the coupled orbital response over the 14-day window, producing a finite optimum and then a shallow plateau. At 800 km, however, the same drag-induced roll-over is pushed beyond the sampled range, so increasing A/m continues to improve the short-horizon gain throughout the tested envelope. The shared conclusion is that stronger SRP authority is beneficial, but the accessible benefit depends on how strongly drag competes over the observation window. Compared with the density sweep, the A/m response remains broad at both altitudes, but only the lower-altitude case shows a clear local optimum within the sampled range.

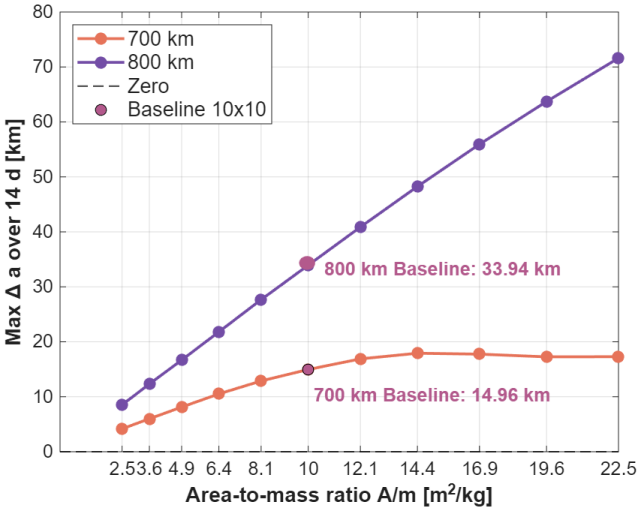


Figure 13: Sensitivity of the 14-day maximum semi-major-axis increase, $\Delta a_{\mathrm{max,14d}}$, to sail area-to-mass ratio for the gain-anchor case, with spacecraft mass held fixed at 10 kg, shown for the same reference geometry at 700 km and 800 km. The 700 km response is non-monotonic, with a broad optimum near $A/m = 14.4\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$, whereas the 800 km response continues to increase across the full sampled range.

8.4. Interpretation of the sensitivity envelope

Taken together, the three sweeps support a restrained but more nuanced conclusion. The transient gain behaviour is not a numerically singular point: it persists over a finite neighborhood in roll and over a broad range of positive A/m, and this admissible neighborhood expands significantly between 700 km and 800 km. At the same time, the mechanism is still not a generally robust passive orbit-raising mode. Its existence remains contingent on favourable Sun-orbit-attitude phasing and on a drag environment weak enough for the eclipse-biased SRP work surplus to remain positive over the observation window.

The most defensible statement is therefore that the gain occupies a bounded local envelope whose size depends materially on altitude. Roll sensitivity demonstrates finite but limited alignment tolerance at 700 km, but a substantially wider tolerance band at 800 km. Density sensitivity shows that drag remains the dominant bounding mechanism, while also showing that the regime can lie either close to or well away from the drag-dominated breakdown threshold depending on orbital height. Area-to-mass sensitivity shows that stronger SRP authority improves the short-horizon gain broadly, but that the onset of diminishing returns is itself altitude-dependent and is shifted to larger A/m at higher altitude. These results are consistent with the broader thesis of the paper: the mechanism is real and physically interpretable, but it is geometry-bounded, alignment-sensitive, and ultimately limited by the coupled drag and orbital-distortion effects that later drive the long-horizon transition from transient gain to decay.

9. Independent numerical validation: an open-source propagator cross-checked against STK Astrogator and Orekit

The reduced-order analysis of Sections 6–8 establishes the passive-gain regime within a single dynamical model. Because the regime is narrow and depends on a delicate balance between eclipse-gated SRP work and atmospheric drag, its credibility rests on two things being demonstrated independently: first, that the gain region *exists* and is not an artefact of one numerical implementation; and second, that the propagator used to map it is itself trustworthy. This section addresses both. We re-implement the model in an independent, open-source propagator and cross-validate that propagator, component by component, against two established flight-dynamics environments: Ansys Systems Tool Kit (STK) with the Astrogator module [23, 24], and Orekit [27], the open-source flight-dynamics library used operationally by several European space agencies and industrial operators.

The motivation is practical as well as methodological. Solar-sail and drag-sail concepts are increasingly demonstrated in low Earth orbit on low-cost CubeSat and small-satellite platforms — NanoSail-D [15], CubeSail [16], InflateSail [17], and CanX-7 [18] — precisely because LEO offers a cost-effective, rapidly accessible test environment for maturing sail technology before committing to expensive deep-space missions [19, 20]. Reliable pre-flight prediction of the coupled SRP–drag dynamics for such demonstrators requires propagation tools whose force models have been verified against a recognised reference. Open-source propagators (GMAT [26], Orekit [27], poliastro [28], Basilisk [29], Tudat [30]) make such studies reproducible and inspectable, but they must be validated; cross-checking an open-source propagator against STK/HPOP is an established verification practice [25, 26].

Using two reference tools rather than one turns out to be essential. As reported below, STK Astrogator could not be configured to exercise the SRP model this problem actually requires, and it disagreed with the open-source propagator on drag decay by close to an order of magnitude. With a single reference, neither observation can be attributed: the discrepancy might lie in either tool. The second reference resolves both.

9.1. Open-source propagator

The independent propagator integrates the equations of motion of Section 4 directly in Cartesian ECI coordinates with a fixed-step fourth-order Runge–Kutta scheme at a 30 s step. The force model comprises: (i) central gravity with the J_2 zonal term; (ii) atmospheric drag using the piecewise-exponential U.S. Standard Atmosphere 1976 density profile [40] with a frontal area $A|\cos\theta|$ projected onto the instantaneous velocity and no atmosphere co-rotation; and (iii) solar radiation pressure represented by a single body-fixed flat plate. The sail normal is constructed once, at epoch, from the local time of descending node, inclination and pitch angle and then frozen in inertial space, consistent with the passively spin-stabilised assumption. A binary cylindrical umbra gates the SRP. Mean (secular) elements are recovered by stroboscopic sampling of the osculating semi-major axis at ascending-node crossings, which removes the $\pm 9\,\mathrm{km}$ J_2 short-period signature that would otherwise mask the few-kilometre secular signal of interest.

The SRP plate is modelled with the physically consistent specular/diffuse/absorptive decomposition of the flat-plate force [41, 42], which places the specular component along the plate normal with a $\cos^2\alpha$ dependence — exactly the form of the reduced mechanism model (Eq. 8). Calibrating the plate to specular reflectivity $\rho_s = 0.7$ and diffuse reflectivity $\rho_d = 0$ gives a normal-incidence coefficient $C_{r,\mathrm{eff}} = 1 + \rho_s = 1.7$, matching the reflectivity coefficient of Table 2. An offline check confirms that this plate reproduces the paper's $C_r \cos^2\alpha$ acceleration magnitude to within 1.6% for incidence angles $\alpha \leq 45°$. We emphasise that the along-normal (specular) direction is essential: an SRP force directed along the Sun line performs zero net orbit-averaged work in this geometry (the positive and negative arcs cancel), so only the normal-directed plate reproduces the eclipse-gated pumping mechanism.

9.2. STK Astrogator configuration

The STK reference cases were built entirely through the STK 13 Object Model API driven from Python, running the STK Engine headlessly so that large parameter sweeps could be executed without the graphical interface. Each satellite uses the Astrogator propagator: a Mission Control Sequence with an Initial State segment (Keplerian elements in the Earth inertial frame) and a Propagate segment terminated on a duration stopping condition. A dedicated numerical propagator was cloned in the component browser and its force-function collection configured to match the paper's model: a gravity-field function truncated to degree 2, order 0 (J_2 only, tides disabled); an atmospheric-drag function using the built-in U.S. Standard Atmosphere 1976 density model; and an N-plate SRP function. The N-plate SRP and drag geometries are supplied through STK plate-definition files specifying, per plate, the area, body-frame normal, and (for SRP) specular and diffuse reflectivities; the sail is represented by a single body-fixed $+Z$ plate for SRP and by two opposed $\pm Z$ plates for drag so that the projected area follows $A|\cos\theta|$. The inertially-fixed attitude is imposed with the standard `eProfileFixedInAxes` profile and a quaternion mapping the body $+Z$ axis onto the sail normal. Osculating elements are read from the Classical Elements data provider and, where a secular quantity is required, orbit-averaged over one nodal period.

9.3. Orekit configuration

The Orekit reference cases use Orekit 13.1 driven from Python through the JPype bridge to the stock Java library, so that no part of Orekit is modified or reimplemented. The mapping onto the paper's model is close to one-to-one. Central gravity is the propagator's own Newtonian attraction evaluated at the paper's gravitational parameter, and the oblateness term is supplied by `J2OnlyPerturbation`, which applies the degree-2 zonal perturbation with the paper's J_2 and reference radius. The inertially-fixed attitude is a `FrameAlignedProvider` carrying a constant rotation that maps the body $+Z$ axis onto the sail normal — the direct counterpart of STK's `eProfileFixedInAxes` profile. The sail is a single `FixedPanel` inside a `BoxAndSolarArraySpacecraft`, Orekit's N-plate model, with optical coefficients $(\alpha_{\mathrm{abs}}, \rho_s, \rho_d) = (0.3, 0.7, 0)$. As in the STK build, two panel instances are required, because a single Orekit panel carries one two-sidedness flag while the sail is one-sided for SRP and two-sided for drag; the one-sided panel is given to the radiation-pressure model and the two-sided panel to the drag force.

Two configuration choices deserve comment. First, Orekit's shadow model is selected to be `CylindricallyShadowedLightFluxModel`, a binary cylindrical umbra with no penumbra, which is exactly the shadow model the paper specifies; Orekit's more commonly used conical model would have introduced a penumbra difference unrelated to the question being tested. Setting the occulting radius of the same model to zero yields a permanently illuminated sail, which is how the eclipse-off branch of the causality test is realised without touching any other model element. Second, Orekit ships DTM2000, NRLMSISE-00, JB2008 and Harris–Priester but not the U.S. Standard Atmosphere 1976, so the paper's piecewise-exponential profile is injected by implementing Orekit's `Atmosphere` interface and delegating the density lookup to the same tabulation the open-source propagator uses. Everything else in the drag path — the atmosphere-relative velocity, the projected area, the force assembly — remains Orekit's. Because that interface must then declare its own atmosphere-frame velocity, the co-rotation assumption becomes an explicit switch, which is exploited in Section 9.7.

Physical constants are pinned to the paper's values in every constructor rather than left at Orekit's defaults, so that residual differences reflect how each tool *applies* a force model rather than which reference ellipsoid or gravitational parameter it prefers. Two quantities are deliberately left as each tool's own and are quantified rather than removed: the Sun ephemeris, where Orekit reads DE-440 while the reduced model uses a low-precision analytic series at a fixed one-astronomical-unit distance, and the integrator, where an adaptive Dormand–Prince 8(5,3) scheme with eclipse event detection is available alongside the fixed-step scheme used by the open-source propagator. Over the 75-day study window the two Sun models differ by at most 0.37° in direction; more consequentially, the true Earth–Sun distance departs from one astronomical unit by up to 1.67%, and because the epoch falls within days of perihelion the reduced model understates the solar flux by about 3.4% at the start of every run.

9.4. Component-level agreement

The finest-grained test evaluates every force separately at identical states. Sampling one orbit at the gain-anchor geometry and evaluating both tools at each of the 198 sampled states gives maximum relative vector differences of 2.8×10^{-17} for gravity, 3.2×10^{-14} for drag and 1.0×10^{-15} for SRP, with the eclipse flag agreeing at every sample and the plate normal recovered from Orekit's propagated attitude matching the frozen sail normal exactly. At the level of the individual force laws, in other words, the two implementations are the same function to within floating-point round-off.

The pointwise drag check that the STK comparison rests on behaves likewise. At a matched state near 700 km the two tools return identical density and identical instantaneous drag acceleration to 1.5×10^{-16} relative, against the $\sim 4\%$ agreement obtained with STK. This comparison also exposes a fragility in the atmosphere tabulation itself that is worth recording. The sixteen-segment piecewise-exponential fit anchors each layer at its own floor with its own scale height, and those anchors were not chosen to join up: extrapolating any layer to the floor of the next reproduces the next layer's anchor density to better than 2% at none of the fifteen boundaries, with jumps of 11–21% throughout the 200–1000 km range and factors of 1.198 and 1.206 across 700 and 800 km specifically — that is, across both study altitudes. The study orbit, with $e = 10^{-4}$ and true anomaly zero at epoch, begins just *below* the 700 km boundary and therefore samples the denser layer. Quoted at exactly 700.000 km the tabulated density is $3.07 \times 10^{-14}\,\mathrm{kg\,m^{-3}}$, within 4.1% of the $3.2 \times 10^{-14}\,\mathrm{kg\,m^{-3}}$ read back from STK; quoted at the sampled state it is $3.71 \times 10^{-14}\,\mathrm{kg\,m^{-3}}$, 15.9% higher. Two lessons follow: a comparison of LEO drag models at a nominal round altitude should state which side of a layer boundary it was evaluated on, and a piecewise-exponential atmosphere intended for this kind of study should be built to be continuous.

Finally, the analytic SRP calibration of the reduced model is confirmed against a second implementation. Sweeping the incidence angle and comparing Orekit's N-plate against the reduced $C_r \cos^2 \alpha$ law reproduces the manuscript's own figure closely: the worst magnitude deviation for $\alpha \leq 45°$ is 1.55%, against the 1.6% obtained offline. The direction offset between the two grows to 35° at $\alpha = 45°$, which is not a disagreement but the physical content of the reduced model: the N-plate force acquires an along-normal specular component that the Sun-line-directed reduced form does not carry, and it is precisely that component which does the orbit-averaged work.

9.5. Propagated cross-validation

Figure 15(a,b) compares the propagators for the conservative and dissipative parts of the model at 700 and 800 km, in the configuration chosen so that the result cannot depend on sail orientation (J_2 plus spherical U.S. Standard Atmosphere 1976 drag, no SRP, $A/m = 10\,\mathrm{m^2\,kg^{-1}}$, $C_D = 2.2$). For the conservative dynamics the mean semi-major axis of the open-source propagator and STK agree to better than 0.05 km over a 14-day propagation; against Orekit the same comparison agrees to 2.8×10^{-10} km.

The drag comparison is where the two reference tools separate, and it is the principal validation finding. Against STK, the *instantaneous* drag acceleration at a matched state agrees to within $\sim 4\%$ (both $\approx 1.9 \times 10^{-5}\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}$ at 700 km, with comparable density), yet the *propagated* 14-day mean semi-major-axis decay differs by close to an order of magnitude: −84 km for the open-source propagator against −7 km for STK. Against Orekit the same 14-day decay agrees to 3.7×10^{-10} km, both tools returning −84.040 km at 700 km and −21.898 km at 800 km. The divergence is therefore not symmetric between the tools: two independent propagators return the same trajectory, and the difference is localised to how STK applies drag over the trajectory rather than to the open-source implementation.

This agreement should be read for what it is. The two propagators share the density tabulation $\rho(h)$, because U.S. Standard Atmosphere 1976 is what the model specifies, and they share the integration scheme and step; what is independently exercised is Orekit's orbit and frame handling, its attitude provider, its assembly of the drag and radiation forces from a panel geometry, its shadow model and its Sun ephemeris. Agreement at the tenth decimal is stronger evidence about force assembly and coordinate handling than about the atmosphere, and the following subsection addresses the atmosphere directly.

9.6. Solar radiation pressure under a passively fixed attitude

The SRP comparison surfaced a practical limitation of the industry tool. In our configuration STK Astrogator's built-in N-plate SRP model did not apply the satellite's inertially-fixed attitude to the plate body frame: the effective Sun-facing plate area reported by STK was zero for the passively oriented sail, so the model produced no SRP force for this

attitude mode, and an SRP-only propagation was indistinguishable from a J_2-only one. Industry flight-dynamics N-plate models are designed principally for actively pointed or Sun-tracking spacecraft, and are not readily configured for a plate whose normal is frozen in inertial space. With a single reference tool this could only be reported as a limitation, and the open-source SRP implementation had to be validated analytically instead.

Orekit's N-plate model does not share the limitation, and the same test passes cleanly (Fig. 15c). The plate normal recovered from the propagated attitude reproduces the frozen sail normal to 1.2×10^{-16} across the whole pitch range; the effective Sun-facing area follows $A \cos \alpha$, taking the value $90.8\,\mathrm{m}^2$ at the anchor pitch of 24.8° where STK reported $0\,\mathrm{m}^2$, and vanishing only at true edge-on incidence; and the resulting force follows the flat-plate law to 1.8×10^{-14} relative. Propagated, the distinction is unambiguous: over 14 days at the 700 km anchor with drag disabled, J_2 alone gives $\Delta a = -0.012\,\mathrm{km}$ while J_2 plus N-plate SRP gives $\Delta a = +14.61\,\mathrm{km}$. The passive-sail SRP dynamics are therefore reproducible in an established third-party flight-dynamics library, and the gap the STK comparison had to leave open is closed. The limitation remains a useful result — it is a real obstacle a practitioner will meet — but it is now identifiable as specific to that tool's N-plate configuration rather than as an intrinsic difficulty of N-plate modelling, which is consistent with the higher-fidelity SRP literature in which faceted models are tailored to specific spacecraft geometries and pointing modes [43–46].

9.7. Locating the inter-tool drag difference

Three candidate explanations for the drag divergence suggest themselves: the atmosphere-relative velocity treatment (whether the atmosphere co-rotates), the altitude convention used for the density lookup (geodetic or geocentric), and the definition of the secular element itself. Each can be switched independently in Orekit while everything else is held fixed, so the question can be settled by measurement rather than by argument. Figure 16(a) collects the result.

None of the three is large enough. Making the atmosphere co-rotate with the Earth changes the 14-day decay at 700 km from −84.04 to −86.97 km, a factor 1.04; looking the density up at height above the WGS-84 ellipsoid rather than above a sphere changes it to −68.09 km, a factor 0.81; applying both gives −70.29 km. Switching the mean-element definition from stroboscopic node sampling to an orbit-averaged energy mean moves the endpoint by less than one percent. Combining every one of these choices in the direction that reduces drag cannot bridge a factor of twelve, and two of the three push the decay the wrong way.

The atmosphere *model*, which the manuscript identifies as the dominant uncertainty but which the STK comparison held fixed by construction, is a different matter. Substituting Orekit's own Harris–Priester model for the same sail multiplies the decay by 5.89 at 700 km — enough to drive the sail below the integrable regime on day 10.5 — and NRLMSISE-00, driven by the CSSI space-weather record, multiplies it by 2.15; at 800 km the corresponding factors are 2.64 and 1.33. The spread across atmosphere models is thus one to two orders of magnitude larger than the spread across every convention the two tools might reasonably have differed on. Note also the direction: every alternative atmosphere *increases* the decay, whereas STK's is twelve times smaller. With the conventions ruled out by measurement, the remaining candidates lie inside STK — most plausibly the density its built-in model applies along the trajectory, as opposed to the single epoch value that was read back and did match, or its handling of the effective drag area. Neither can be interrogated further without re-running STK, which requires a licensed Windows environment; we therefore report the discrepancy as localised rather than resolved.

The methodological conclusion is unchanged in direction but sharper in content. Atmospheric drag is the dominant and least portable element of the force model for a sail's extreme area-to-mass ratio [47], and it is the *choice of density model*, not the co-rotation or altitude conventions, that carries that uncertainty. Any LEO sail prediction should therefore report the atmosphere model and its driving indices alongside the result.

9.8. Numerical sensitivity of an eclipse-gated force

A second, less expected finding concerns the numerics rather than the physics. A binary umbra makes the SRP acceleration discontinuous in time: it switches between its full value and zero at every shadow entry and exit, roughly thirty times a day in this orbit. A fixed-step Runge–Kutta scheme cannot see that switch — it evaluates its stages on both sides of the jump and smears the transition across one step — and because the crossings are phase-locked to the orbit the resulting errors accumulate rather than cancel. Both the open-source propagator and the STK runs used fixed steps.

Orekit makes the test possible, because its cylindrical shadow model publishes eclipse event detectors: with an adaptive integrator, the propagation is stopped exactly at each shadow boundary, restarted, and each continuous arc is integrated cleanly. Figure 16(b) sweeps the fixed step from 120 s down to 2.5 s for three configurations. The two configurations with continuous forcing — drag only, and SRP with the umbra disabled — are essentially step-independent over that range. The eclipse-gated full model is not: the 14-day $\Delta a_{\max}$ at the reproduced 800 km gain geometry falls monotonically towards the event-detected reference as the step is reduced, and at the 30 s step used by the open-source propagator it overstates the converged value by a few per cent of the gain. The overstatement is modest at 30 s but roughly doubles at 60 s, a step size that would be unremarkable in a parameter sweep.

The practical implication is specific: for eclipse-gated SRP problems, part of a reported gain can be an integration artefact, and the effect grows with the step size that large sweeps encourage. All Orekit results reported for the gain

regime below therefore use the adaptive integrator with eclipse event detection.

9.9. Independent confirmation of the gain regime

Using the validated propagators we re-ran the parameter-space sweep and the representative cases in Orekit as well. The existence of the passive-gain regime is confirmed independently a second time: Figure 17(a) reproduces a single connected lobe of positive $\Delta a_{\max}$ over a bounded band of LTDN and *positive* pitch angle, in agreement with the location of the lobe in Figure 2 and with the open-source reproduction of Figure 18. The eclipse-causality result is likewise reproduced: at the reproduced 800 km gain geometry, toggling the umbra flips the 30-day mean semi-major-axis response from +8.21 km to −31.95 km, confirming that eclipse timing — not merely SRP magnitude — controls the sign of the orbit-averaged SRP work. At the 700 km anchor the same toggle changes −114.8 km to −416.3 km: the eclipse gating is still doing the same work, but drag is too strong there for it to change the sign. The one-orbit SRP power profile (Fig. 17b) shows the eclipse removing the negative-work arc, and the long-horizon evolution (Fig. 17c) reproduces the characteristic transient: the 800 km gain case rises to +8.48 km on day 35.2 and then falls to −7.11 km by day 75, with eccentricity growing from 1.4×10^{-4} to 1.24×10^{-2}, apogee pumping from 801 to 882 km and perigee eroding from 799 to 704 km, while the 700 km anchor decays to reentry by day 36 — the same day the open-source propagator gives.

The quantitative diagnosis of Section 6 is also independently corroborated. At the reproduced 800 km gain geometry Orekit gives a net per-orbit SRP work of $+309\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ with the umbra active against $+0.8\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ without it, with 76.8% of the eclipsed samples falling on what would otherwise have been the negative-work arc. The eclipse-off value confirms the mechanism exactly as stated — without shadowing the SRP work over an orbit cancels to within a part in four hundred of the eclipsed value — while the eclipsed magnitude sits close to the open-source figure and about a factor 2.6 below the $+799\,\mathrm{J\,kg^{-1}}$ of the reduced model. Two independent propagators therefore agree both that the mechanism is real and that the reduced model overstates its magnitude.

The independent reproduction also sharpens the interpretation of the effect. In both open-source and Orekit models the clearest gain lobe appears at 800 km, whereas at 700 km the same geometry is drag-marginal; the peak reproduced excursion is smaller than the reduced-model estimate. The density-sensitivity sweep makes the cause explicit: reducing the atmospheric density recovers multi-kilometre gain even at 700 km, so the altitude and magnitude at which the regime becomes net-positive are governed primarily by the assumed drag model. Read together with the atmosphere-model spread of Section 9.7, this identifies the choice of atmospheric density model — not the SRP mechanism — as the dominant uncertainty in predicting where the passive-gain regime is realisable. The mechanism itself (eclipse-gated, geometry-selective, transient and self-limiting) is robust across three propagators; its quantitative threshold is drag-model dependent and should be reported together with the atmosphere model used.

9.10. Data and software availability

The open-source propagator, the STK Astrogator build and sweep scripts, the Orekit port and its validation battery, the plate-definition files, the cross-validation utilities and all reproduced figures are archived in the project repository [48] so that the results of this section can be independently reproduced and extended. The Orekit study is self-contained: it installs the stock library from a package index, fetches the public Orekit data archive, and imports the open-source propagator's force code verbatim rather than re-transcribing it, so that each comparison is between two tools rather than between two typings of the same equations.

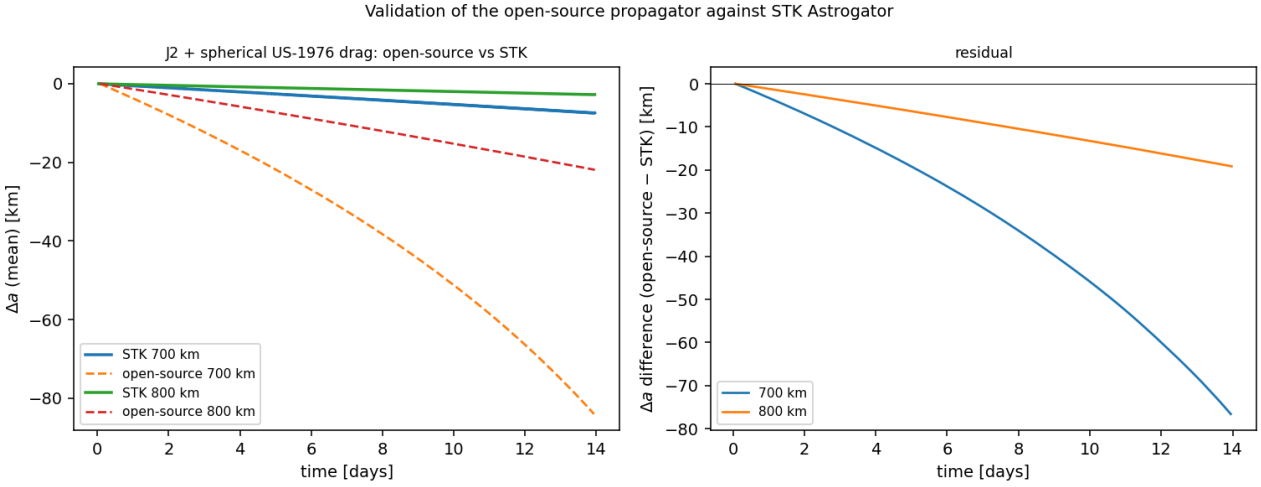


Figure 14: Cross-validation of the open-source propagator against STK Astrogator for J_2 + spherical U.S. Standard Atmosphere 1976 drag (no SRP), a configuration whose result is attitude-independent. Left: mean semi-major-axis history at 700 and 800 km. Right: the residual (open-source − STK). Two-body plus J_2 dynamics agree to < 0.05 km over 14 days; the drag-induced decay differs by close to an order of magnitude despite matching instantaneous force.

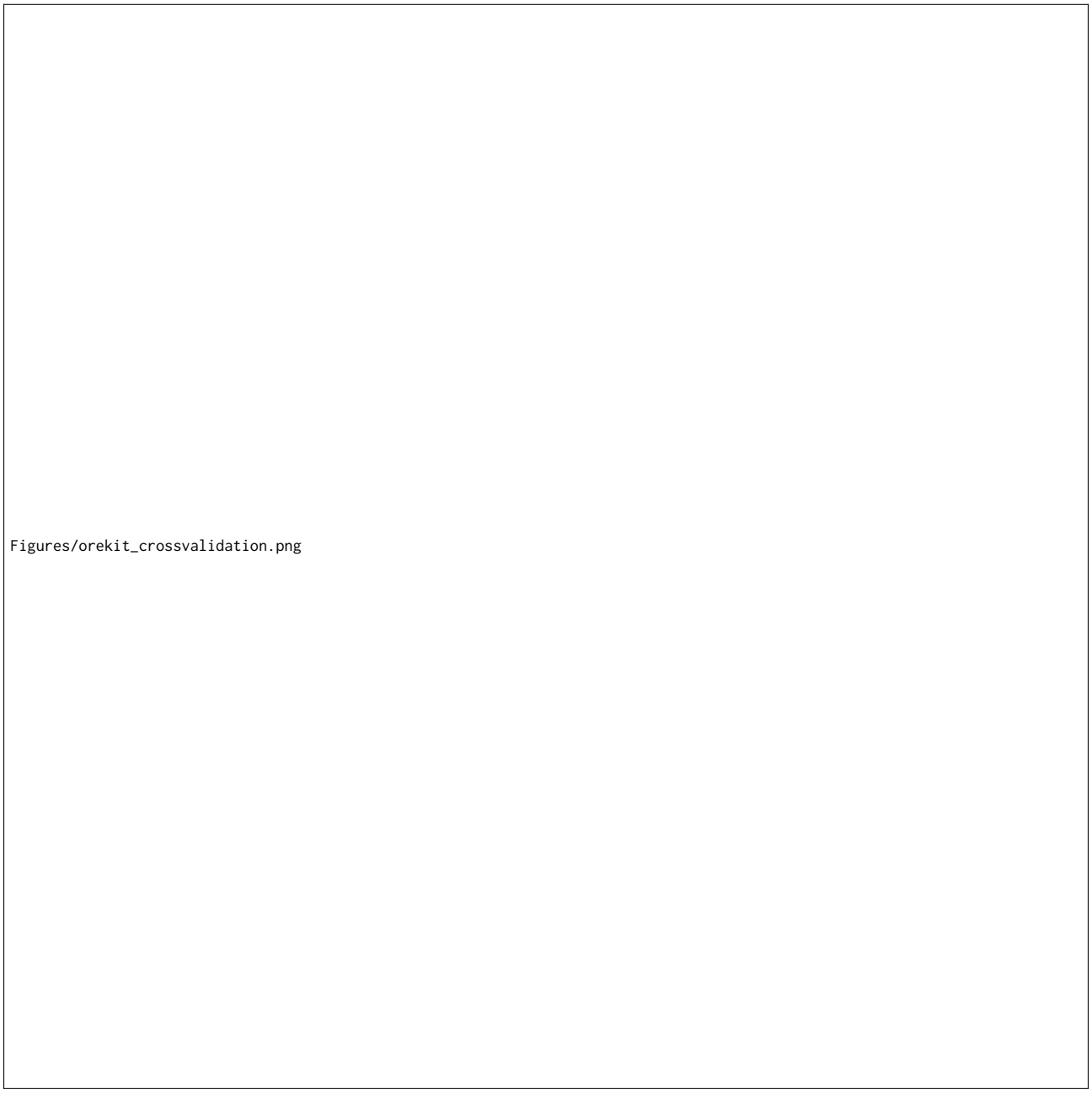


Figure 15: Cross-validation against Orekit 13.1. (a) Mean semi-major-axis history for J_2 + spherical U.S. Standard Atmosphere 1976 drag; the open-source and Orekit curves are indistinguishable at this scale, and STK's reported 14-day endpoint at 700 km is marked. (b) Absolute residual between the open-source propagator and Orekit for all four configurations, against STK's quoted 0.05 km agreement bar and the 77 km STK–open-source drag gap. (c) The test STK could not pass: effective Sun-facing area of the N-plate SRP model as the sail pitch is swept, for a normal frozen in inertial space. Orekit follows $A\cos\alpha$; STK reported zero for every pitch.

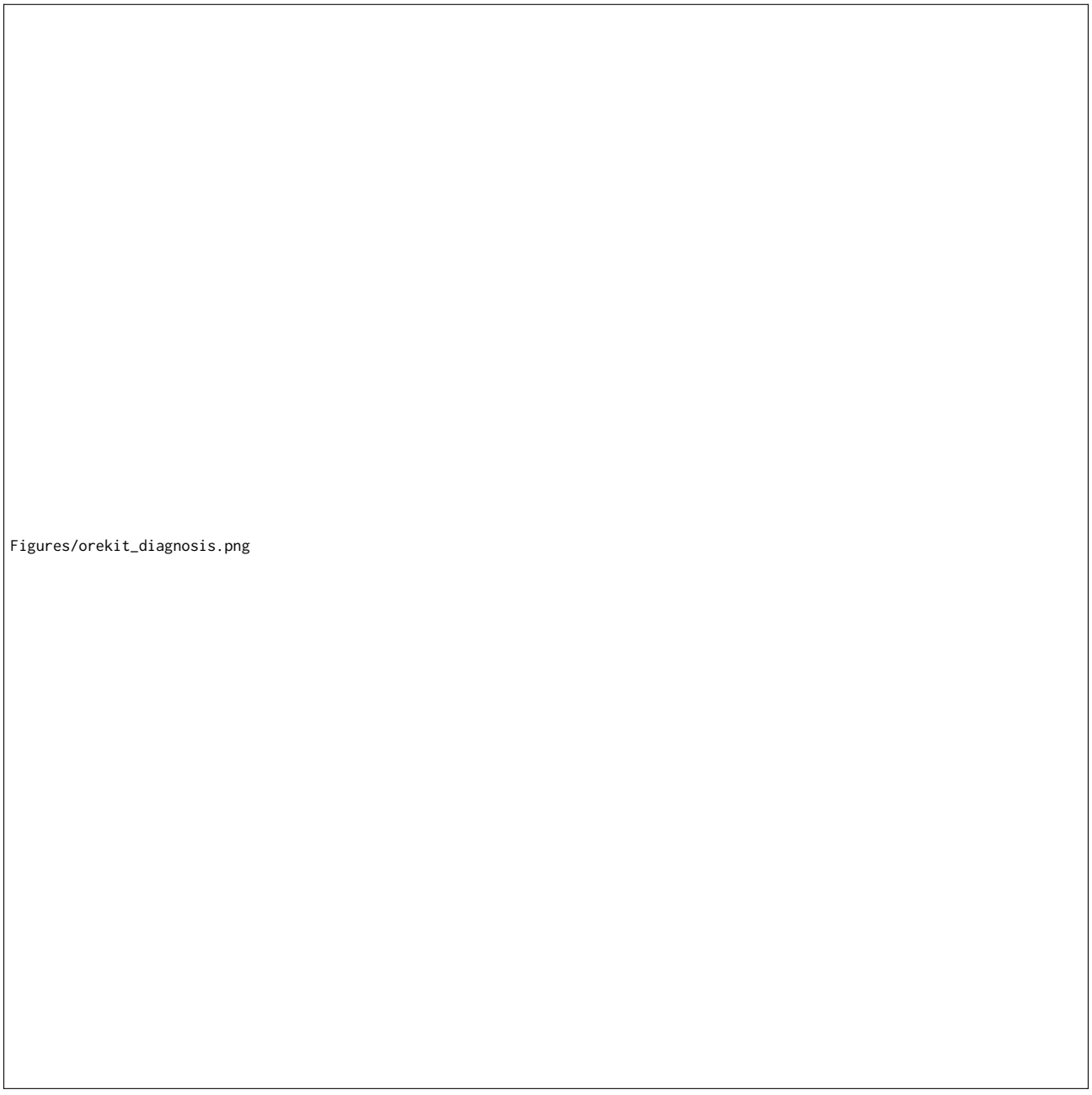


Figure 16: Locating the inter-tool differences. (a) Drag modelling choices isolated one at a time in Orekit, all other elements held fixed: atmosphere co-rotation and the geodetic-versus-geocentric altitude convention move the 14-day decay by tens of per cent, whereas substituting a different atmosphere model moves it by factors of several. STK's reported 700 km endpoint is marked. (b) Step-size sensitivity of the eclipse-gated force at the reproduced 800 km gain geometry: the two continuous-forcing configurations are step-independent, while the full model converges towards the event-detected adaptive reference only as the fixed step is reduced.

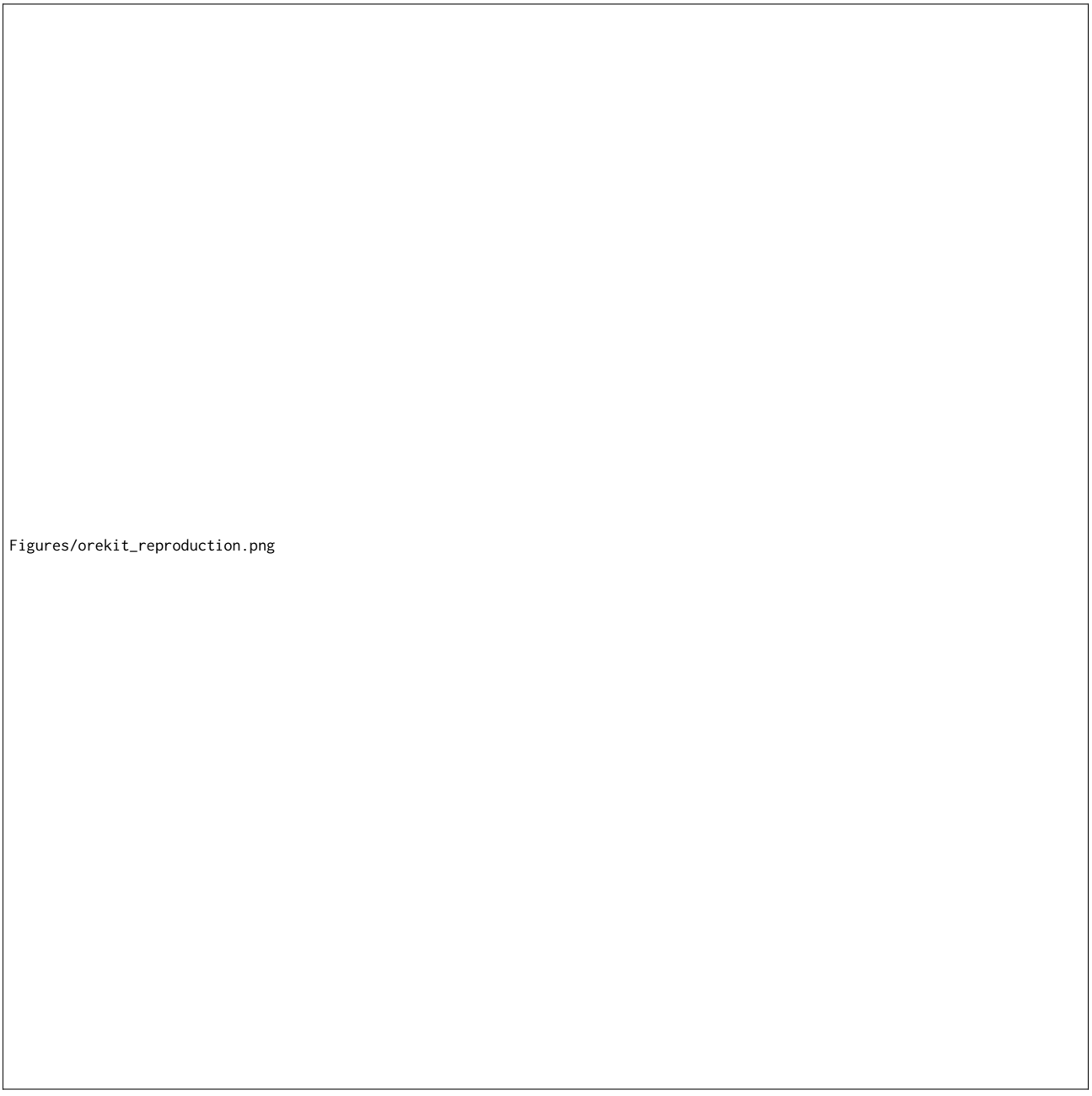


Figure 17: Independent reproduction of the gain regime with Orekit. (a) 14-day $\Delta a_{\max}$ over LTDN and sail pitch at 800 km, showing a single connected positive lobe at positive pitch over a bounded LTDN band; the star marks the reduced-model anchor and the circle the Orekit peak. (b) One-orbit SRP specific power at the reproduced gain geometry, with the umbra shaded and the no-eclipse reference dashed: eclipse removes the negative-work arc. (c) 75-day mean semi-major-axis evolution for the reproduced 800 km gain case and the 700 km reduced-model anchor, showing the transient, self-limiting signature.

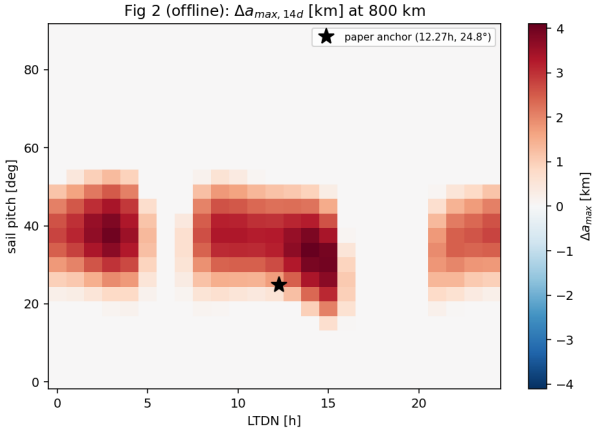


Figure 18: Independent reproduction of the passive-gain lobe with the open-source propagator: 14-day $\Delta a_{\max}$ over LTDN and sail pitch at 800 km. A single connected positive lobe appears at positive pitch over a bounded LTDN band, in agreement with the location of the reduced-model lobe (Fig. 2); the star marks the reduced-model gain anchor.

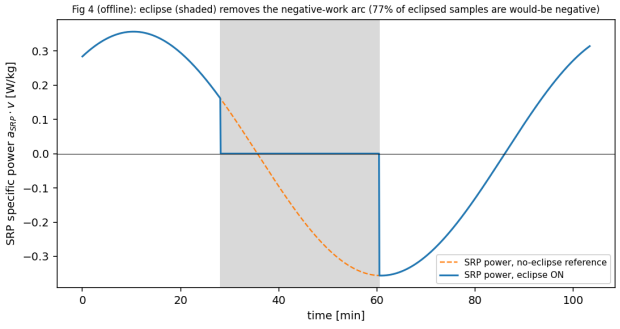


Figure 19: One-orbit SRP specific power for a reproduced gain case. The dashed curve is the no-eclipse reference; the shaded interval is the umbra. Eclipse removes the negative-work arc, flipping the orbit-averaged SRP work positive — the eclipse-gating mechanism, reproduced independently.

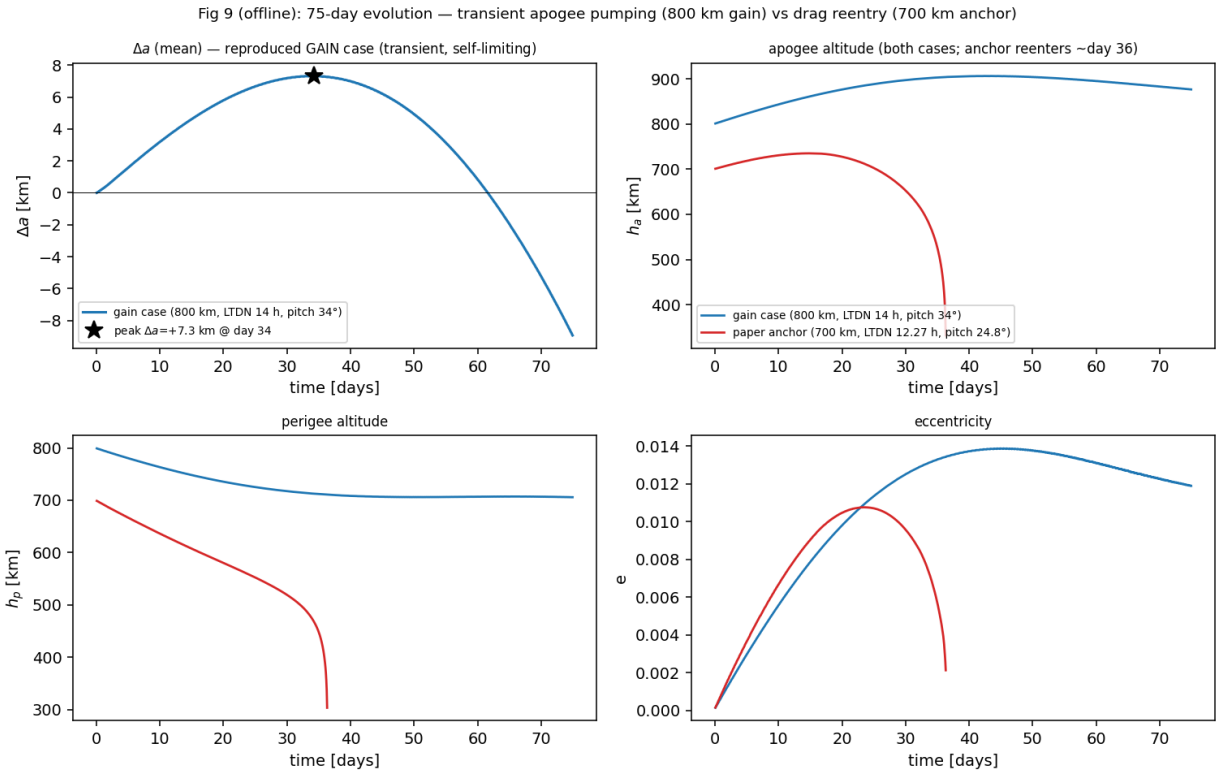


Figure 20: Reproduced 75-day element evolution. The gain case (800 km, blue) shows the transient, self-limiting signature: mean semi-major axis rises to a peak then declines below its initial value, with apogee pumping, eccentricity growth and perigee erosion. The 700 km reduced-model anchor (red) is drag-dominated and decays to reentry, illustrating the drag sensitivity of the regime.

10. Conclusions

This paper examined whether a passively oriented, spin-stabilised solar sail in near-polar low Earth orbit can exhibit a bounded interval of net orbital-energy gain under eclipse-modulated solar-radiation-pressure forcing. The results show that such a regime does exist, but only over a narrow and well-defined region of the sampled LTAN–pitch space. The gain response is therefore not a generic property of passive sailing in LEO, but a constrained transient effect that appears only under specific Sun-relative geometries.

The results also show that eclipse is the causal enabler of this transient gain regime. In the representative gain case, the inclusion of eclipse produces positive short-horizon semi-major-axis growth, whereas removing eclipse from the same initial condition eliminates that behaviour and leads instead to clear decay. Orbit-resolved SRP work diagnostics show why: eclipse does not merely weaken SRP forcing, but selectively removes unfavourable portions of the SRP cycle. Under the gain geometry, this shifts the orbit-averaged SRP work balance positive; under neutral and decaying geometries, the same shadowing instead suppresses the positive recovery branch and leaves the net SRP contribution negative. The central physical result is therefore that eclipse timing can control the sign of the orbit-averaged SRP work input.

At the same time, the longer-horizon behaviour shows unambiguously that this effect is transient and self-limiting rather than sustained. The representative gain trajectory initially exhibits semi-major-axis increase, but this does not correspond to uniform orbit raising. Instead, the orbit evolves through apogee growth, perigee erosion, and rising eccentricity, so that the early energy advantage progressively creates the conditions that undermine it. Drag becomes increasingly concentrated near perigee, while the favourable SRP projection weakens as the orbit distorts. As a result, the late-time orbit-averaged energy balance turns negative and the semi-major axis ultimately declines below its initial value. The transient gain regime identified here must therefore be understood as a front-loaded energy imbalance, not as evidence of persistent passive orbital uplift.

The sensitivity analysis supports the same interpretation. The gain-anchor case is not a numerically isolated point, but neither is it broadly robust. At lower altitude, the response is strongly limited by density and attitude offset; at higher altitude, the same geometry remains more tolerant over the sampled envelope, but still does not become a general passive orbit-raising solution. The mechanism is therefore physically real and interpretable, yet intrinsically bounded by geometry, atmospheric conditions, and the coupled eccentricity and drag penalties that emerge during the evolution.

The second objective of this paper was methodological, and its outcome reinforces the first. An independent, open-source re-implementation of the model reproduces the gain lobe, the eclipse-driven sign reversal of the orbit-averaged SRP work, and the transient apogee-pumping-then-breakdown signature, demonstrating that the regime is a property of the dynamics and not of a single numerical implementation. Component-by-component cross-validation of that propagator against STK Astrogator shows excellent agreement for the conservative dynamics (two-body and J_2 agree to better than 0.05 km over 14 days) but a near order-of-magnitude divergence in the drag-induced decay, despite matching instantaneous drag force.

Cross-validating against a second, independent reference proved decisive in interpreting that divergence, and is the methodological lesson we would most want carried forward. Orekit reproduces the open-source propagator's force components to machine precision and its 14-day drag decay to sub-micron agreement, so the disagreement is attributable to STK's drag application rather than to the open-source implementation — an attribution that no amount of further work with a single reference could have supplied. Orekit also passes the test STK could not: its N-plate SRP model does couple to an inertially fixed sail normal, so the passive-sail SRP dynamics are now confirmed against an established third-party library rather than only analytically. The practical finding that industry N-plate SRP models are not readily configured for a passively, inertially fixed sail therefore stands, but as a limitation of a particular tool's configuration rather than of N-plate modelling as such.

Isolating each candidate explanation in turn sharpens the physical conclusion. Atmosphere co-rotation and the geodetic-versus-geocentric altitude convention each move the 14-day decay by at most about a fifth, and the choice of secular-element definition by less than one per cent, whereas substituting a different atmosphere model moves it by factors of up to 5.9. It is therefore the choice of atmospheric *density model* — not the SRP mechanism, and not the drag conventions the two tools might reasonably have differed on — that dominates the uncertainty in predicting where the passive-gain regime becomes net-positive, and this explains why the reproduced regime is most clearly realised at higher altitude, where drag is weaker. A final, transferable caveat concerns numerics rather than physics: a binary umbra makes the SRP force discontinuous in time, so fixed-step integration converges at first rather than fourth order across the shadow boundaries and overstates the gain, appreciably so at the step sizes that large parameter sweeps encourage. Studies of eclipse-gated forcing should use event-detected integration, or demonstrate step-size convergence.

Accordingly, the main contribution of this paper is twofold: scientifically, it establishes that a constrained transient gain regime exists, that eclipse timing is its causal enabler, and that the same coupled dynamics that permit the early gain also drive its later breakdown; and methodologically, it delivers and validates an open-source toolchain — released openly [48] — for reproducibly studying passive-sail SRP–drag dynamics in LEO, which is increasingly the low-cost testbed of choice for sail technology. Because the quantitative gain threshold is shown to depend on the atmosphere model, future work should report results together with the density model and its driving indices, tighten the

analytical bounds for the gain window, reconcile the remaining STK drag discrepancy against in-orbit or higher-fidelity atmospheric data, and study whether limited attitude variation — informed by optimal steering approaches such as those of Dachwald [33] and McInnes [13] — can delay the eccentricity- and drag-driven breakdown without altering the fundamentally transient character of the effect.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Data availability

The open-source propagator, the STK Astrogator build and sweep scripts, the plate-definition files, the cross-validation utilities and all reproduced figures are openly available in the project repository [48], as described in Section 9.10.

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